MACHINE TRANSCRIPT · CORAGGIO CONSULTING

Virginia Board of Education, Work Session, Wednesday, October 23, 2024

Date	Wednesday, October 23, 2024
Place	Virginia Board of Education (Virginia Department of Education), Richmond, Virginia
Length	7h 5m (video)

- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3Vv7l5N2PaM
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

> Machine transcript (speech-to-text) produced by Coraggio Consulting. Not an official county record. Names and numbers may be misspelled; check the video at the timestamp before quoting.

Speech-to-text: whisper.cpp, model large-v3-turbo. Produced 2026-10-23. Each paragraph starts with its time [HH:MM:SS] in the meeting video.

[00:11:34] Good morning. It's 9.01 a.m. and I will now call this meeting to order. Dr. Coons, do you have any comments? I do not. It says. You might. Okay, we will now move into our closed session, which we hope to keep brief, but we shall see.

[00:11:51] Mr. Hansen, would you make our motion to go into closed session, please? Thank you, Madam President. I move that the Virginia Board of Education convene in a closed meeting for the following purposes, discussion or consideration by the Board of Education of information relating to the denial, suspension, or revocation of teacher licenses subject to the exclusion in subdivision 11 of section 2.2-3705.2 pursuant to section 2.2-3711A40 of the Code of Virginia and consultation with counsel regarding specific legal matters requiring the provision of legal advice pursuant

[00:12:30] to Virginia code section 2.2-3711 of the code of Virginia and the legal counsel to the board of education and staff whose presence will aid in the board's consideration of this matter participate in the closed meeting is there a second second dr. Bryce aye mr. Rotherham aye Dr. Northern aye Mr. Hanson aye Ms. McPherson um Ms. Kilgore aye Ms. Holton aye and chair votes aye

[00:13:08] okay we're in closed session now you ready all right so at this time chair will entertain a

[00:50:17] motion to certify the purpose of the meeting in closed session uh Mr. Hanson we convened today in a closed meeting pursuant to a recorded vote on the motion above in accordance with the freedom information act section 2.2-3712 of the code of virginia requires that the board certify that to the best of each member's knowledge only public business matters lawfully exempt from open meeting requirements under this chapter and only such public business matters as were identified in the motion by which the closed meeting was convened were heard discussed or considered

[00:50:52] any member who believes there was a departure from these requirements shall so state prior to the vote indicating the substance of the departure that in his or her judgment has taken place the statement of the departure will be recorded in the minutes motion has been made by mr hansen is there a second second okay and the motion has been seconded by miss kilgore um all those in favor signify by saying i opposed no dr bryce aye mr rotherham aye dr northern aye uh mr hansen

[00:51:27] aye miss mcpherson all right miss kilgore miss holton aye and chair votes aye motion carries um okay so our next item is going to be voting on a series of licensure matters which were discussed in our closed session in the case number 2024-2021 the chair will entertain entertain a motion to issue a teaching license to the applicant okay a motion has been made and seconded we will proceed

[00:52:01] to the vote. Dr. Bryce? Aye. Mr. Rotherham? Aye. Dr. Northern? Aye. Mr. Hansen? Aye. Miss McPherson? Aye. Miss Kilgore? Aye. Miss Holton? Aye. And chair votes aye. Okay. Motion carries.

[00:52:17] In case number 2024-019, the chair will entertain a motion to revoke the teaching license of Diego Honorado Valencia. So moved. Second. A motion has been made and seconded. We'll now proceed to the vote. Dr. Bryce. Aye. Mr. Hansen. Aye. Mr. Rotherham. Aye. Dr. Northern. Aye. Ms. McPherson. Aye.

[00:52:44] Ms. Kilgore. Aye. Ms. Holton. Aye. And chair votes aye. That motion passes. Okay. In case number 2024-023, the chair will entertain a motion to revoke the teaching license of roger allen mckay so move okay we'll proceed to the vote dr bryce hi mr rotherham hi dr northern

[00:53:15] hi mr hanson mcpherson miss kilgore ah miss holton hi and chair votes i and that vote is passed unanimously also um at this time the board will go into an additional closed session mr hanson uh-huh uh now this one the highlighted piece for that yeah okay please mr hanson i move that the virginia board of education can be in a closed

[00:53:52] meeting for the following purposes consultation with legal counsel employed by or retained by a public body regarding specific legal matters requiring a provision of legal advice by such council pursuant to section 2.2-37118 of the code of virginia and the legal counsel to the board virginia board of education staff whose presence delayed in the board's consideration of this matter participate in the closed meeting is there a second second okay um mr rotherham or i'm sorry

[00:54:27] Dr. Bryce? Aye. Mr. Rotherham? Aye. Dr. Northern? Aye. Mr. Hansen? Aye. Ms. McPherson? Aye. Ms. Kilgore? Aye. Ms. Holton? Aye. And Chair votes aye. Thank you. We're in closed session. Mr. Hansen, can you read our certification, please?

[02:01:35] We convened today in a closed meeting pursuant to a recorded vote on the motion above and in accordance with the Freedom of Information Act, Section 2.2-3715 of the Code of Virginia requires that the board certify that to the best of each member's knowledge, only public business matters lawfully exempt from open meeting requirements under this chapter and only such public business matters as

were identified in the motion by which the closed meeting was convened were heard, discussed, or considered.

[02:02:05] Any member who believes there was a departure from these requirements shall so state prior to the vote, indicating the substance of the departure that in his or her judgment has taken place. The statement of the departure will be recorded in the minutes. Dr. Bryce? Aye.

[02:02:22] Mr. Rotherham? Aye. Dr. Northern? Aye. Mr. Hanson? Aye. Ms. McPherson? Aye. Ms. Kilgore? Aye. Ms. Holton? And chair votes aye. Just so everyone is aware, we're going to take a break until 11 o'clock, so you have eight minutes, and then we will come back.

[02:02:40] Thank you.

[02:13:13] Thank you, everybody. We will move to presentation A, which is ELA 6 through 12 materials, K-12 math materials, by Deputy Superintendent of Teaching and Learning, M. Cooper.

[02:13:29] Ms. Cooper, are you ready? Thank you. All right. Good morning, President Carisi, members of the board, and Superintendent Coons. in accordance with the constitution of virginia and the code of virginia the textbook review process was established to align with the standards of learning revision process which occurs at least once every seven years the current available board approved list of secondary textbooks for reading and writing was adopted in 2018 and then after the 2017 english standards of learning

[02:14:05] revision. With the adoption of the 2024 English Standards of Learning by the board in March, the department followed the board-approved textbook review process to curate the list of proposed textbooks that I am bringing before you today for first review. This review process focuses on grades 6 through 12 for reading and writing at each grade level. It's also important to note that the K-5 core instructional programs have been adopted under a similar process but defined under the 2022 Virginia Literacy Act. Today we're recommending for first review 60 proposed

[02:14:41] English textbooks. Six publishers submitted materials for consideration. There were two publishers who withdrew seven of their textbooks as they did not correlate with the 2024 English Standards of Learning. Also want to acknowledge the hard-working teachers and supervisors who were part of the review process who helped us get to where we are today. Their experience was valuable and their contributions and expertise were really essential to getting the list where it is on slide two you'll see in 2024 the board of education approved the 2024 standards for

[02:15:16] divisions to fully implement those this school year and are awaiting an approved list to adopt the necessary textbook so the textbook list we bring to you today is for again grade 6 to 12 ELA, and the board's authority is to approve textbooks and other instructional materials per the Constitution and Code. The Code also establishes that any textbook contract price shall not exceed the lowest wholesale price at which textbook or textbooks involved in the contract are currently underbid anywhere in the United States, so this really removes barriers for school divisions so they don't have to consider inconsistencies in pricing by publishers.

[02:15:56] The next slide highlights the criteria used by the review committee. The department followed the board approved process for criteria for both sections one and two of the review process. We had 42 secondary educators from across the Commonwealth reviewing their proposed textbooks using those correlation documents approved by the board.

[02:16:19] The first part of the review, committee members rate textbook alignment to the 2024 Standards of Learning for Reading and Writing. And then in the second part of the review, they are assessing how each textbook addresses instructional planning and support.

[02:16:34] On slide four, you'll see that we originally had seven publishers that expressed interest in the textbooks review. One publisher did not pursue the process further, so we had six total submissions for grades 6 to 12.

[02:16:52] based on the committee's review two publishers withdrew a total of seven textbooks from consideration we're on slide four of which what the ela we don't have yeah madam president it's confusing this holden it's it's i had the same thing it's on the on the one on the board site there's not links but on the sharepoint site it's all linked for the work session

[02:17:22] but then what comes up is on that call matt oh um maybe is it the same as the presentation for tomorrow's business session is that where it is yeah that's in that only that maybe it's the is it the same presentation that yeah it's probably attached to tomorrow it could be as well Can you give us just a second to pick up with us?

[02:18:00] Yes. Item M is it? Item M at the bottom. Item M.

[02:18:17] Item M. Okay. Four. Are we all caught up? All right. So based on the committee's reviews, two publishers withdrew a total of seven textbooks for consideration for not sufficiently correlating to the 2024 English Standards of Learning.

[02:18:53] The list of 60 proposed secondary textbooks recommended is included in your attachment D, and the list includes five publishers. On the next slide, you'll see the timeline that began in April. So following the board's approval to the textbook review process, we began the review of the textbooks. We had interested publishers contact the department. They were asked to submit a publisher certification and agreement form for each of the textbooks they were submitting. We reviewed the submitted information and responded confirming their

[02:19:31] intent and outlining the board approved process. After that meeting, the department posted the announcement in the Virginia Education Update, notifying publishers of the opening of the process and seeking nominations for qualified members for our textbook review committees. We reviewed those applications and selected 42 classroom educators, reading specialists, and English content supervisors from across the Commonwealth to be a part of this process. In June, during the summer, our committee members conducted individual analyses of the materials using the evaluation criteria for the

[02:20:11] standards of learning correlation content and design for instructional planning and support they then submitted their reviews to the team and then between august and september the staff review documents that were submitted by them to gain consensus reviewed all the submitted textbooks and then aggregated those analyses for each textbook in order to draft the consensus letters publishers were given an opportunity to respond to the committee's reviews and recommendations and then the staff again reviewed the request by those publishers after they submitted and that is how we got the compiled list of proposed and approved

[02:20:48] textbooks to present to you all today for next steps on slide six you'll see the 30-day public comment will begin on October 25th and remain open until November 23rd. And then in December, we anticipate bringing back the final list of recommended textbooks for secondary English at the December

board meeting for approval. The textbooks on the proposed recommended list will be available digitally on the VDOE English page. We'll also have instructions for submitting public comment. And the deadline again for public comment is November 23rd. We'll then review all

[02:21:27] of that public comment and report findings to you all in December to consider the list of textbooks for final review then. And then after those are approved, we will notify school divisions with the approved list and then give details of profiles of each of those approved curriculum.

[02:21:44] And I'm happy to answer any questions. Dr. Morether? Are you going to do math in a minute or should we wait to do our questions after math or would you rather us? I'm going to do math next, but up you okay i think i'll just wait to do math that kind of okay so um i'm guessing it's the same presentation that we have in the work session but if we'll go ahead and click on the one that's in the before i have a question on as to this okay she said that she wanted to maybe take them all

[02:22:21] questions on english and math together that's yes thank you all right so moving to the math presentation. So, similar to the ELA review, the Code of Virginia gives the Board of Education the authority to approve textbooks and instructional aids. The alignment of textbooks and instructional materials with the state's academic standards provides our divisions with materials to set students up for success. On the timeline slide, again, similar to ELA, but want to walk through

[02:23:00] this as well. After the board approved our 2023 math standards of learning, that is when the textbook review process began. That was in October of 2023 when those were reviewed. The initial process produced a limited number of textbooks for adoption. And due to that, we revised the timeline to extend the window to allow publishers the opportunity to submit instructional materials in addition to the k-12 textbooks the addition of the high quality materials is intended to further support teachers in the classroom and divisions in making those decisions for their

[02:23:37] schools on april 25th in 2024 the board authorized video to proceed with that revised textbook process at this time all the publishers that submitted math textbooks and materials were given the opportunity to provide a rebuttal to any of the consensus evaluations similar to ela publisher responses were examined by department staff and the math review committee and then those reports of all of the approved textbooks will be available again on the video website and can use

[02:24:12] be helpful for divisions to use when selecting materials the textbooks and materials that are recommended to move forward are included in attachment to the rubric used in the approval process was comprised in two sections so again similar to ela the first part of the review is for the alignment to the math standards and then the second piece is around the specific pedagogy evidence-based strategies and resources that are a part of that curriculum in terms of next steps you'll see on the next slide we'll also have a 30-day public comment period that will begin

[02:24:52] October 27th. Digital access to the materials will be available on the VDOE page. The board will review public comments and consider final approval of the textbooks and materials at the December board meeting. And then again, once approved, we will provide that list with details for each of those curriculum two divisions, and we'll continue to do ongoing cycles of review after that. And I am happy to answer ELA and math questions. Okay. Dr. Northern? So we've had an

[02:25:28] opportunity to chat about this. And I just wanted to kind of make the broader board aware. I think one concern I'm having is that we don't have enough publisher developers throwing their hat in the

ring. And I think, you know, historically, Virginia has not been a big player like Florida or Texas or some of these other big states. But we want, you know, we want to be a player, right?

[02:25:51] And so I would just encourage, you know, I don't know if our publisher friends watch these meetings. But we definitely want some more curriculum to review. And one of my concerns is that we don't have curriculum providers who provide a full novel experience. A lot of our teachers teach by using full novels, and there are several curriculum that actually use that to teach our skills and knowledge that we're requiring in our Virginia ELA. And there are just like four or five,

[02:26:25] even six curriculum that other states are adopting that have been proven to pass muster by other big reports that do these types of curriculum evaluations nationally. And I'd hate to see us lose out on using some of those other curricula that other states are doing. So again, I'm glad that we have more time uh for for um publishers to um to um you know uh apply to us um i also my other sort of concern is that we encourage our reviewers to crosswalk some of their reviews with ed reports

[02:27:01] ed reports by no mean is not the be-all end-all holy grail but they do have a pretty rigorous process that's been in place for a while and i did notice that we passed several uh curriculum that ed reports did not pass or that partially met. And that may very well have to do with misalignment with the Virginia standards and not, you know, something else. But it would be good to encourage our reviewers to look at those reports and just cross-check that they're being as rigorous as we would like them to be. I did notice that all 60 programs were passed by our teams. I'm not

[02:27:36] saying all 60 programs shouldn't have passed. I'm merely saying that cross-checking our reviews with an external organization that does these reviews will be helpful. And on the math side, I'd say the same thing that I feel like we don't have enough providers and vendors throwing their hat in the ring. And also same idea that two or three of the reports that did not meet the ed reports criteria, we approved, our teams approved. So again, any assistance where they can have some external benchmarking, I think would be useful. If again, if it's not lining up to the Virginia

[02:28:10] standards that's one i get that but it could be something else um and i think that is the totality of what i wanted to say mr rotherham madam president i i when when we get to uh final i will be recusing on this because of uh uh relation professional relationship consulting relationships but i think i can say the following without running a foul i would like to amplify two points one i was also surprised on the math uh the the limited number of of providers um uh even though

[02:28:46] even with that limited number i'm conflicted out um and then second uh the point on on full books and novels students need to be reading books they need to be reading books at the high school level and we need to be supporting our teachers who are still pushing back against in some cases considerable pressure not to have kids reading books and to sort of move to sort of not to debate even what the great books but like the great passages and we need to push back uh we push back against that so i i very strongly concur with that that we should put a priority if we want kids to there's so many benefits to reading books both academic and then also sort of just broader social benefits

[02:29:23] of the ability to take a text and work it and understand it and so forth and i just think we have to be for you know we're limited with the standards and some of the things we can do but i think as a board we can foursquare send a signal that is our expectation that students will be reading rich, rigorous, diverse text and engaging with those.

[02:29:41] Ms. Hulton? So, echoing my colleagues' remarks, but in particular on the math, I'm just concerned that the K through, that we actually did have, if I understand correctly, 14 publishers submit, not all for all grades, but that a number did submit for the early grades and only one made the cut for k through there's only one publisher on the approved list for k through five and i i i don't know whether that is that consistent with how many how many math textbooks

[02:30:20] are on the approved list for the the last round is that unusual to have only one choice and uh what if anything can we do about that at this late date uh dr northern said something about that there's more time to apply i missed that is there more time to apply is there more opportunity to review and i do think on the math the the issue may not be so much of publishers not applying but for what and i'm very grateful to the committees who know did all that hard work that i would not be competent to do reviewing textbooks but it looks like there were quite a few publishers who

[02:30:58] submitted on unlike on the ela but a few publishers who submitted but who are not recommended to go forward. Particularly in the K-5, I see at least one, two, three, or four, I think, who submitted and only five who submitted for the K-5 and only one who made it through. So obviously, we can't go back and fix whatever the problems are in those textbooks. But any insight, Emma,

[02:31:34] And is that a problem for school divisions to have only one approved? I know school divisions can go outside of our approved list, but they use our approved list and it solves, you know, helps them through the procurement process.

[02:31:50] Is that going to be an issue? Sure. So a few things. As part of the process, all of the publishers receive feedback after that initial review and then are given an opportunity to submit a rebuttal. two of those publishers withdrew based on that information because they weren't aligned to standards. So that was their choice to not resubmit during that process. So you're right, there were some that did not move forward. We will have additional cycles of review. So this is not the only time that publishers are allowed to submit. We'll have ongoing cycles for both ELA

[02:32:26] and math so that publishers can submit at different points of the year. But in other words, for school divisions that may be initiating a textbook selection process this spring, they're only going to have one choice on the state approved list for math for the early grades?

[02:32:44] As of right now, yes, this would be the first approved list, but we will have additional cycles for them. And how many typically do we have on the approved list? Have we ever had just one approved in the past? I'd have to go look that up. It just would seem to me very troublesome in a procurement process to have only one on the approved list.

[02:33:07] Ms. McPherson? In that regard, you say that the school board seems to be textbooks that are not approved by the board. The matter that the school board selects such books in accordance with regulations formigated by the board. So can you tell me how restrictive our regulations are?

[02:33:26] Do they have to choose textbooks that are at the same price within that price range? or what options do they have if they say, guess what, we don't think that book will work and we've got the new revisions to the accountability and accreditation process and we just think something else will work? Can you speak to what the options really are? So you're correct. A local division can choose a textbook that's not on this list. The benefit of having this list is that it's already gone through a process in which we've reviewed for those high-quality pieces of the rubric.

[02:34:03] And so they are allowed to use something else, but this at least has gone through the process to ensure that it's aligned to standards and then the instructional strategies that we're expecting from high-quality curriculum. Dr. Cairns? And do we release those findings as Member Hilton spoke about?

[02:34:20] Some of them did not make. Do we release that? So if school divisions choose to go outside the list, they know where the challenges are and what they need to do to supplement? We can. And if they go outside the list, they have to go through their own procurement process, in other words. So it's a burdensome process for smaller divisions, and that's why at least smaller divisions typically do rely on our list.

[02:34:45] Well, again, I don't know what, if anything, we can do about it this late date. I don't know whether this year was different from normal because of the, you remember, the math went through a particularly convoluted process because the timing was accelerated due to us.

[02:35:01] not having a transition year on the math standards the way we have in the past, I don't know whether that created a problem or what, but, you know, or, and if, did I hear you say two publishers have withdrawn, but are there two, maybe, are there some still going through a rebuttal process that might catch up with this round? You know, I don't know whether the rebuttal process also includes an amendment. Can they fix whatever the deficiencies are? They could. So they can choose to submit the rebuttal or not. Two chose not to, the rest did. So, and that's ongoing? No, it's, they have a time

[02:35:39] period in which they have to submit and then the rebuttal is reviewed for alignment again, and then it's determined if they're approved or not. And are we, is the process of reviewing those rebuttals ongoing? It has finished for this cycle. So they've submitted rebuttals, but their rebuttals were not adequate. Correct. So for this cycle, there's only going to be one choice for K-5. Wow. And, and do

[02:36:03] Do you know whether, Dr. Northam, you're way more, I'm deferring to your wisdom, but do you think the ones that we, are the high quality materials that are not on our list, are they ones, would ed reports give positive evaluation to any of the ones we're rejecting?

[02:36:26] Or would it be, is the omission publishers that didn't come to us or publishers that came to us but didn't make it through our criteria? I'd like M to answer that because you know, I'm not sure Dr. Northern knows the ones that were in the rebuttal process, the four that were in the rebuttal process, have those been approved by ed reports? I would need to go and verify that. I can, I'm happy to do that. Because yeah, maybe that's the way to think about it. If they have, is there anything worth, is there, is it worth taking another look before we get to final decision? You know, our standards are different

[02:37:05] from the Common Core, but they're not that different on math. I mean, math is math. We'd be happy to do that. We'd be happy to take those four in the rebuttal and compare them to reports and come and send an update on that. We'd be more than happy to do that.

[02:37:20] I just, if there's anything we can do to give school divisions more options, more quality options more quickly, I'd love to see us do that. And I'd also like us to release the deficiency, So school divisions, as they're looking at materials, see the reviews and the deficiency so they're aware of what the expert reviewer said about the materials that have been reviewed, similar to what we do for K-5 with the VLA partnership.

[02:37:45] I have one more question on a process matter, Ms. Holton. So you all gave us by email last night links to the actual textbooks, and I appreciate that.

[02:38:01] I think I was maybe getting ahead of ourselves, but am I correct in understanding that the approved process, the digital access to the textbooks will be provided to the public as well for the full 30-day comment period?

[02:38:23] Correct. Those are the same links that will be provided. to the public. The one I clicked on had the answer guide, too, so you may want to adjust those links if you don't want to give the public the answer guide. I don't know, maybe we do. So that's my question. So they'll all be publicly available. They're available to us, too, and I would just say by way of a comment to my fellow board members that we used to have a couple of board members, Jim Dillard and Elizabeth Lodl, who actually reviewed the textbooks quite

[02:39:01] carefully and had useful feedback. And when they rolled off, some of the rest of us have tried to take a peek at them a little bit, but it's a lot. And obviously, we don't have the expertise that the committees do. But I do remember on at least one occasion, us looking at them and raising issues in particular. There were some science textbooks, I remember, for example, that had a lot of pictures of scientists, but none of them were women. And we raised that and the textbook provider fixed it like right on the spot. It's all digital. So I just encourage us to, obviously we can't do it

[02:39:38] before tomorrow, but tomorrow is just first review. So before December, within our realms of expertise, if we have an opportunity to take a look and provide feedback through the department, I encourage us to do so. Ms. McPherson? Yes. Question on that ongoing cycle. Do you have any dates yet for when there'll be more cycles and reviews and more opportunities to submit yeah those are being finalized right now we want to make sure that's for both ela and math and then

[02:40:08] we're also working with vlp for the k5 ela cycles as well other questions okay thank you all right we are moving to item b which is a presentation by school leaders from bath county brunswick county norton city and hopewell city we're so excited to have them with us today and of course we'll have a discussion take place after the presentation um and i do think we might want to do some i'm

[02:40:45] gonna do an opening okay we're gonna have each team come up so as part of this some of our presenters have brought goodies and they are going to ask that the board sit in the audience so that we can see the amazing work of the school divisions so i would love it if we could transition now and have the board sit in the audience we're going to have sam and jim move that table out of the way um in real time because they're so awesome and then um i'm going to open and then i'm going to have each of our team members come down we have worked very specifically with the library of

[02:41:21] Virginia to drop the screen behind us at 11:40. So this is a very tightly timed presentation to get us with the Library of Virginia because they are providing some extra services so we can actually show a video that one of our school divisions provided. So you may have a little movement around depending on which school divisions come first, but we are so excited to be here today.

[02:41:50] So as our board members are turning around, I do just want to mention that we know on the onset of 2023 that COVID learning loss demonstrated significant challenges for our third through eighth graders who suffered much lower performance than we had ever seen before.

[02:42:09] Chronic absenteeism had also increased significantly and meaningfully impacted performance. Our General Assembly and our governor dedicated $418 million at the beginning of 2023 to provide school divisions with multi-year intensive tutoring, less and chronic absenteeism challenges, and

accelerate the Virginia Literacy Act. We know that our school divisions all had different challenges and implemented in different ways, but we're bringing to you four bright spots that took on that challenge at the beginning of 22-20 or 23-24 last year and came out with

[02:42:47] tremendous results. So we're really excited. I want to review just quickly before they get up here that in September we made the all-in announcement. Between October and December our school division submitted plans around attendance, around tutoring, and around literacy and really took intentional time to say this is what we're focusing on this is what we're already doing we have additional funds how are we going to target those funds and they had the autonomy to design programs around these three areas or if they felt there was another need that was really

[02:43:23] important in recovering their students they also made those choices those all-in plans were posted on our website are still posted on our website we have school divisions that have updated those As they are iterating and looking at their data and seeing their needs, they continue to refine those all-in plans and really have had the opportunity to target and focus based on what they are seeing in their data and their needs.

[02:43:46] Those statewide programs were also asked. So we've talked a little bit about Ignite and Lexia and Zern and some of the work we're doing in that process of developing those all-in plans. We had a lot of school divisions say, we're doing this, but we also need this.

[02:44:02] Is there any way you could help us? So we went through a contracting process for ZERN for mathematics, and math from ZERN provides a supplement to in-person tutoring and a supplement support. In addition to ZERN as a supplemental tutoring program, there's a robust product of professional development for educators on math concepts behind that. So not only can our teachers teach the ZERN lessons and do the tutoring with ZERN or support the tutoring with ZERN, we can have non-math educators provide that support through the ZERN tutoring resources, the professional development and spaces. So, ZERN not only provides

[02:44:41] that support, but they provide those professional resources for maybe alternative educators who are tutoring in mathematics. In addition, we partnered with Ignite, and Ignite does very intensive one-on-one virtual early literacy tutoring for students who really have challenges in that early science of reading, the sounds to symbols, the symbols to word, that very basic construction of reading. And so we were really excited, but we had a greater need in literacy than Ignite could provide. So Lexia came alongside and subcontracted with Ignite to provide statewide support for some

[02:45:18] of those lighter touch literacy needs that students need around standards work, around comprehension, around practicing those literacy skills. So we have school divisions doing that. I think, and I might misspeak, I think we have 119 of 131 school divisions who are using one of these forms and these platforms to support their work.

[02:45:39] We have applied to the U.S. government and expect and have given verbal confirmation that we will be able to continue those services through 2526 for all school divisions. If we need to supplement some of that dollars, we will use that on our state set aside to make sure that those programs were not only available last year, starting in January, this year, through the entire school year, and next year.

[02:46:05] So, school divisions can take advantage of all three of those resources this year. We saw high-intensity tutoring happening across the state. Some school divisions hired additional tutors. Some used

their own teachers. Some tutored before school.

[02:46:21] Some redid their schedules to incorporate tutoring during the school day, some did after school, and some did intersession approaches. We are working to collect that data and better understand where we're seeing those bright spots and help school divisions continue to iterate, but we really are seeing that intensive tutoring and that high-intensity tutoring is a significant support.

[02:46:43] We know that school divisions have offered additional hours. We know that school divisions, and we had more offerings, some are programming and some are resourcing as well. you're going to hear from one school division that uses a balanced calendar and extends their year to provide additional time and support. So we're very excited about that work. We also know that this year is our formal Virginia Literacy Act year, but we had school divisions really leaning in last year, depending it was training, whether it was letters training, letters support, bringing your teachers together, working through that high quality instructional material process for K-5, whether it was working with the reading specialists to redesign schedules and think

[02:47:19] about those things. We had over 142 hours of professional development that had occurred across the state to support our educators as well. And then last but not least, I'm really proud of the work that happened around attendance. We've been recognized nationally by AEI. We're being recognized by Excel and Ed in November about our work in attendance. We moved 16.1% of our rate around attendance, which was overall from 19 to 16 percentage points. We saw 85% of our school

[02:47:55] divisions reduce chronic absenteeism. But I just want to give this stat because I'm really proud. Over 9 million of additional hours of instruction were received by students based on changes of attendance. If our students are getting 9 million more hours of instruction with all of the things that we just talked about, that's a game changer. It's a game changer and an opportunity. We did the statewide chronic absenteeism task force. We did our chronic absenteeism toolkit. We had a symposium, but I am going to let our teams from the schools talk about some of the things that they really

[02:48:31] leaned into to show how different and unique each school worked on attendance and how they attacked that. So without further ado, I'm going to have Superintendent Bowling come up and chat about the reading case study and the work that he did in Bath County to really change the numbers.

[02:48:56] Bath County moved from a 66% passing rate in 22-23 to a 78.5% passing rate, which is a 19% point passage rate change in one year? Good morning and thank all of y'all for being here.

[02:49:21] I would start by saying one thing that I've been blessed with is a great public education from the Commonwealth of Virginia, which I think prepared me for college and beyond. And further, I'm proud to be the superintendent of Bath County, Virginia, but my ties in growing up and working in Wise County of Virginia for 22 years, I think, gave me some exemplary models of hard work and dedication and putting people first. My approach to leadership has always been that you have to have high expectations of everybody, including yourself, and you have to model the way and do what you're

[02:49:59] going to say. I think that coupled with the priority on relationships and taking care of people first, and that's what leads to retention of our staff, but you also have to make data-informed decision making um and that's maybe the more cold side of that but we all have a limited amount of time and we have equal so we have to do things that are producing results and we have to either refine that or move to

other things along the way when we i came to bath can we have a lot of great people but we needed to kind of refine some of the things and work together in a united direction

[02:50:36] so what we did when we got the all-in funds and i was really beneficial i think it's been i really am grateful for that. I think it's one of the best investments that we had. Different things work differently for different areas, but I prioritized the people first, and most of our money went directly into the pockets of our staff members, because I thought that they were the best if I could give them guidance on how to provide direction, academic work with our students.

[02:51:04] And I believe a lot of it came down to just all working together. The principals and I had a lot conversations. We were small enough that I was able to be in the schools a lot. We had a critical position that was vacant the last seven or eight weeks of school, so I think I maybe spent about 15 days teaching in that classroom, and some of our other principals did that, and we kind of worked together as a team, and when it came to doing the remediation, I went up and worked with our high school students, and I think we just cheered them on individually, and we were all looking at it more

[02:51:41] based on the individual being able to succeed and when they did we succeeded more as a whole and it kind of was able to change the mindset which is how we were able to move forward. Another thing that we did was I really realized that in Bath you kind of operate on an island. For instance when a biology teacher is vacant there's nobody else to be their mentor or a physical science teacher for instance so what we did was we come up and I really do prefer in person but if you can make it quality what I thought was could I get data on some of the student the say for instance

[02:52:20] biology or physical science teacher that we're getting the best results in the state with a diverse group of students over a long time and maybe work with their superintendent to make break communication with their principal to set up a virtual mentorship for the year and we did that where they met via zoom one hour a week and to give it structure so that it had a purpose we talked about them reviewing their assessments their lesson plans and different things along the way and giving review material so we ran that with two teachers who were new to the area that

[02:52:58] were critical that did not have mentors directly in the county and we invested in that two hours a week and I think that's what led a lot to the results but I think a lot of it just comes down everybody working hard and working together and being good to people, but also not accepting excuses to not succeed is very important. But I thank you. Hold on. I'm just going to give you some tangible things because Superintendent Bowling is pretty humble. When he says he went into classrooms, he also ran an entire regional network around literacy practices for his region.

[02:53:39] he took every single staff member and when he says he put money in their pocket every single staff member tutored every single staff member and created a division-wide tutoring program you adopted hqim early and you created a whole community-wide focus on literacy so i'm just really proud of the work you did and how you use the resources and the teams and then thought outside of the box of how to really connect people so thank you so much for doing that hard work and driving to be here to be recognized today and thank you all and one thing i will say again

[02:54:15] though is it is always going to be a team approach and if everybody works together you can succeed and i think that's the bottom line is i can't do it alone our principals can't do it alone but if we all work together then we can accomplish this thank you thank you kevin can we have one more regular or do

we need to do the screen next we're going to have brunswick come down and brunswick County, I'm going to give, while they're giving a chance to come down, Brunswick County had a

[02:54:48] grade 3-8 pass rate of 53.1 percent in the 22-23 school year and increased percentage pass rates by 21.3 percent in just one school year in mathematics. I'm going to have this team up and talk about the things they did for Matt and Dr. Christy Majette. All right, good morning.

[02:55:14] Board of Education President, Mrs. Creasy, Board Member, Superintendent Coons, all assembled. My name is Christy Somerville-Majet. I'm the Superintendent of Brunswick County Public Schools, and I'm honored to be here today alongside my colleague, Mrs. Amy Bianco. She's our Instructional Coordinator and Math Coach, and we do thank you so much for this opportunity to present before you today. We're here to share our exciting news about our progress. Our division is made in grade three through eight mathematics. And as Dr. Coons, I believe, mentioned earlier, we were so honored to be recognized by Governor Youngkin and his administration for our instrumental

[02:55:51] gains that we've made. As a division, small rural school division, we do face some significant financial challenges. And the all-in funding was so critical for us. It allowed us to retain our vital resources. Most importantly, our dedicated human resources, our people, teachers and staff who work closely with our students each and every day and without the support of that funding the board of education our department of education we wouldn't be in the strong position that we are in today and the growth that we've made at this time i'd like mrs bianco to share some of the key

[02:56:30] strategies that enabled our student success over that year good morning and thank you for the the opportunity to be here today. I am going to piggyback off of Dr. Majette to say how fortunate we were in Brunswick County to receive the All-In funding because our human resources are of the utmost importance when it comes to our students. If we don't have people, then how do we teach our kids? And I am fortunate enough to be one of those human resources as an instructional coach for Brunswick County Public Schools and I'm very grateful for that opportunity. Inclusive of

[02:57:09] myself, we also hired several tutors to help us along the way to make sure that our students were receiving all of the instructional benefits and small group instruction that was needed and flexible instruction as well. So I just want to go through some of our evidence-based strategies and things that our team as a Department of Instruction supported in our classrooms. We are in the buildings and in the classrooms each and every week with our teachers and our students.

[02:57:37] We like to call it being in the trenches because as was mentioned earlier teamwork really does make the dream work and that's the way it's going to happen is with us working all together. So one of the first things that we always make sure that we do as a team is ensuring the alignment of our written taught and assessed curriculum. So we want to always make sure that we are providing professional development coaching sessions around providing immediate feedback modeling resources and how to identify which materials are aligned to of course right now the 2023 standards

[02:58:13] but for last year was the 2016 and previously we have the implementation of different types of interactive activities for our students such as daily spiral reviews some say that's my favorite phrase or catchphrase, because I believe that we always have to keep all of the information fresh for our kiddos in order for them to retain it. We can't teach it today and forget it tomorrow, because if we follow that model, they will also follow that model. So the daily SPIAL reviews, the questions of the day, making sure that we use engaging anticipatory sets. We also focus a lot on

[02:58:50] not just our whole group instruction, but our flexible grouping and our stations and our centers to make sure that we are targeting the specific explicit needs of all of our students. We have students that need targeted support in some areas that might seem a little bit low, but we also have students that are succeeding, so we have to make sure that enrichment is there for them too.

[02:59:15] So we have to make sure that we're taking care of all of them through our flexible grouping and instructional strategies. Of course, the implementation, as Dr. Coons mentioned earlier, we have fully welcomed ZERN into our community. We are using it at this point, K through 8.

[02:59:33] We are still this year using it, K through 8. We have already started and implemented and tracking our data, and we are looking forward to the amazing growth that we hope to continue to see as we move forward this year with the utilization of ZERN amongst other high-quality instructional materials.

[02:59:52] Of course, data-informed decision-making. I'm a big numbers person, and so I do believe that our quantitative data is essential, but we also focus on the qualitative data that we're seeing in our classrooms every day, the relationships and the rapport that we have with our students and how we can best meet their needs and making sure that we are focusing on being culturally responsive while we're teaching mathematics and social and emotional responsibility as well.

[03:00:18] so we really kind of infuse all of those. We encourage our teachers to make math relevant every day. Living in Brunswick County is a very rural area, so we try to make as much possible as we possibly can to bring it into the classroom. So I just want to end with saying I'm going to hand it off to Dr. Majette. I am the talker, and I've already said that, but we're just going to keep at it and keep upping the ante, and we thank you for the opportunity to be here today.

[03:00:48] Yes, and thank you, Mrs. Bianco. This is the passion that she brings when she works with teachers and principals and provides professional development. And again, we just thank you so much for this opportunity, the funding with All In and giving us that financial support. And then with Dr. Coons and her team giving us that instructional support, providing programs like ZERN has really been instrumental for us. So thank you again for this opportunity. Thank you.

[03:01:15] I just want to comment, when you heard the word data, like these guys use data for every single student every single day and track data and know exactly where students are. And I love the fact that it's quantitative and qualitative data. I think the focus on data, when I talked to Dr. Majetta, I said, so why? How did you do this? She's like, well, data this and data this and data this and data this.

[03:01:41] And I think that just emphasis on how much the data is infused in instruction, it is a testament to what you're seeing in your students. So thank you very much. Thank you very much. So I think this person may have driven further than anyone else. It may be possibly farther than member Kilgore today from Norton City and John I. Burton High School.

[03:02:08] So Brad Hart is the principal of John I. Burton. I met Brad at, you come on, I'm just going to give you some walk time. I met Brad when he invited me to graduation in my first two months as state superintendent and had the opportunity to just hear these amazing stats of students walking across the stage over and over with associate's degrees, over and over with industry recognized credentials, over and over with military scholarships, and was just so impressed.

[03:02:39] with the data that they were sharing. But then when we got to see the attendance data from last year, this is the top attendance in the state. In 22-23, their chronic absenteeism rate was 25.9%. In 22-23,

their chronic absenteeism at high school was 8.9%, which is lower than our state average before the pandemic. So Brad, that is a drop of 67% in chronic absenteeism. So we'd love to hear how you made that happen with high school students. And thank you for driving from

[03:03:18] Norton City all the way to Richmond. All right, I'm not a public speaker, so just, but I appreciate the opportunity to be here. You know, if anybody's never been to Norton, Virginia, we're closer to eight other state capitals than we are Richmond. And I'd welcome the opportunity. If y'all ever want to come visit Norton, we'd love to have you down there. In Norton, we are a very high poverty

[03:03:54] rate. A lot of kids are single parent homes, if they even live in the homes with a single parent. But we're real small. We try to help each other out. And when it comes to attendance, You know, they don't have people waking them up.

[03:04:13] They don't have rise to school and all that stuff. But we were fortunate enough at John I. Burton High School and Norton Elementary and Middle School to have communities and schools that are a part of our school system.

[03:04:32] And we also got to hire an attendance specialist. And those two things really helped out tremendously with us. But the biggest thing was doing home visits. and you know air city is only seven miles total area so it's it's not a big deal for for myself to to go the house and i tell kids all the time if i don't see you by 8 30 i'm coming to your house and getting you out of bed and you know to see their faces when i knock on the door and their guardian says he's in the bedroom and i'm standing over top of him in their bed sleeping

[03:05:10] and saying you know get up and get dressed that we're going to school you're riding with me um you know that that's the big thing with us um is is just caring um showing those students that we care when you come to Norton you get a free breakfast a free lunch you're safer at you know and and have more opportunities when you're at school than they do uh when they're when they're at their home but uh you know the big thing is is is just you know like everybody else has come up

[03:05:48] here and said, you know, and Mr. Bowling said, if you care about your students and you have a team that has the same feelings as you do, you know, that's what makes it work. And Dr. Coons has been great. She, you know, I don't know, she's been in Dortmund quite a few times and we love when she comes down and visits us. But I appreciate you and thank you all. I know he talked about the communities and schools funding. And I got to meet some of your attendance clerks getting ready to go

[03:06:24] out on the road, pick some kiddos up, make sure they were coming to school. But they also remove barriers, right? If there are needs for the kiddos, they remove those barriers. But I also got to see the after the bell breakfast program in the high school that was going down the hall. The kiddos were coming out, making sure they were fed, that they had what they needed. And then last but not least. I've been in a lot of high schools, but there was like pre-calc happening in heavy duty science, like the rigor in the classrooms. You can't be in bed. You can't miss school. And I think you've created not only a culture of care, but a culture where the kiddos know what they need

[03:07:01] to do and they're getting it done at that graduation. And I think the board has heard me talk about Norton quite a bit in John Ibert in high school. But if you have not had the chance to see the stats around the kids that are graduating they really are walking across the stage and ready for their next step so tremendous thank you thank you for coming to richmond and thank you for being willing to speak i know

i i really had to ask several times but i really appreciate it thank you and last but not least we are going to have hope well city superintendent

[03:07:38] dr hackney and our dupont elementary principal they they have brought a little flair with them they have created a video and we're going to have a screen come down and they are going to show a little bit video of a video but the reason we're having dupont elementary come is because they had at the end of last year a 91 free and reduced economically disadvantaged rate when we looked at their math changes it went from 49.6 to 55.56 49.6 in math 46.8 i can't read from this paper sorry

[03:08:15] 46.8 to 60.2 in math chronic absenteeism went down from 39.4 to 27. we are seeing them they are on the move a high needs school in a high needs community that is on the move and we wanted them to share some of the strategies as a comprehensive school to close us out today on some of the things that they're doing. So I would love for you guys to come up. They're going to play the video. Are we ready, Kevin? We can be. Do you want the video first? You want to talk first? Let me speak first, really quick. She gave me 60 seconds, so I'm going to talk really, really fast. It is an honor to be

[03:08:53] with you all. Good afternoon. I'm proud to introduce Patricia Lobo, our principal of DuPont elementary and i again i'm melody hackney serving my 10th year unbelievable but 10th year as superintendent of hopewell city and my 20th as a superintendent in the commonwealth of virginia i will say that is not by accident um two 10-year gigs to really intentionally stay the course and work hard to move the needle in two very different school districts i think this work it's so important that we all know and appreciate takes time um but we know that sustainable improvement

[03:09:28] and change according to the research takes a minimum of three to five years on average but as we have experienced if we stay the course and provide the needed continuity of leadership especially our our babies can and and will achieve and and our video is going to tell you about how uh lobo and her staff have done that at at um dupont but um i would be remiss if i didn't say how proud I am of your hard work and your leadership and the outcomes specifically at the student level at that school. When I first came to Hopewell, sadly, my greatest observation

[03:10:01] and an observation that was also supported by all stakeholders in our organization, internal and external, was this pervasive culture of low expectations for our children. They didn't even believe that they could do wonderful, magical things.

[03:10:21] It was very tragic, but it became our calling and our mission to make sure that we changed that trajectory for all of them and saw that as an exciting opportunity. So we worked hard at it. We're here today to change that perception once and for all, not just for Hopewell kids, but for all children in Virginia who, as Dr. Kuhn said, live in poverty and struggle with numerous barriers and challenges in school associated with that reality.

[03:10:51] And as she indicated, 91%, 9 in 10 of our babies live in poverty. But we know and believe and now have evidence that they potentially can and will succeed.

[03:11:08] We find the right teachers to connect with them and inspire them and help them to believe that themselves. We embrace the right science-based resources to support our efforts. And then we take the time to close those gaps that have gotten in the way for most, if not all, of their lives.

[03:11:24] It not only can happen, it will happen. So please, please, please don't give up on our children who, at no fault of their own, the most important thing that I'm going to say today, at no fault of their own,

have struggled to succeed because of some of their unfortunate lived circumstances and experiences.

[03:11:45] We owe it to them to never give up, and we celebrate with you, our Board of Education, today that anything is possible, regardless of those circumstances, if we, as the educators, can get it right. Ms. Lobo, you got it right, and I thank you for leading the way, and I thank you, Board, for this unforgettable acknowledgement of our work and the hope of our students.

[03:12:05] So we're going to show you a little bit about what we've done by a fun video put together by our staff and our students at DuPont at this time.

[03:12:30] We are excited to create this success video from DuPont Elementary School. I am Patricia Lobo, the principal, and I am Aisha Baines, the assistant principal. Welcome to DuPont. There are many contributing factors to the success that we've seen at DuPont.

[03:12:48] Clear communication, consistent expectations, constructive feedback, and accountability. However, overall, we would like to think it was the way we all came together as a team for one common goal, student success. Our teachers put their heart and soul into their students and their successes.

[03:13:07] No growth is too small to celebrate. We build lifelong relationships with our students. We learn their likes and dislikes. Then we learn how to teach them and make them successful. It truly is a team effort.

[03:13:23] We've been afforded the opportunity to really think outside the box, to look beyond the classroom to help our students and their families understand them, that we love them, and that we want them to succeed. Morning. My name is Mrs. Seton Smith, and I am a proud educator of 25 years with our special learners here at DuPont.

[03:13:43] So I've been asked the question of how does parent involvement promote success? Well, parental involvement is very important for the success of our students. First thing is that it improves their academic and performance.

[03:13:59] Students tend to learn better when their parents are actively involved, they're engaged in their learning. They tend to get better grades and they tend to have higher test scores. Secondly, involvement with parents also enhances their motivation to learn and it gives them, they tend to value their education because their parents have shown an interest in their learning.

[03:14:22] Another point for parental involvement is the positive attitude that students usually have when their parents are involved. They are usually more connected to the learning and engaged in the learning. Hi, my name is Monica Farrell. My job here at DuPont Elementary is the bilingual family engagement liaison. I work with families, specifically Hispanic families that need help with resources, registrations for school.

[03:14:55] When it comes to absences as well, I establish that connection with them, bridging that gap, given the fact that a lot of these families do not know English and or they have just arrived to the United States.

[03:15:11] states um i do help with events as well here at dupont and it's a way of welcoming those families because a lot of times they are afraid to come to the events because they feel that there's no one that's going to be able to guide them and help them but when they see me it kind of changes and like they light up and they're like okay there's a familiar face um i do love working here i do love my role. I've

established a lot of different connections and relationships with the parents as well as staff. I'm just excited to see what the school year brings.

[03:15:53] I'm Savannah Bryant and I'm a third grade teacher. One intentional strategy that has helped increase engagement in my classroom is allotting times for students to intentionally talk together. we have morning and closing meeting where we work through sel topics report notices of kindness or other skills we are working on and repair damage when incidents occur or behavior mistakes are made as a class modeling appropriate ways to communicate has spilled over to regular content teaching and students are eager to talk in whole group and break out smaller groups with their peers they're comfortable and confident speaking to not only me but other learners in the classroom

[03:16:29] their excitement to share astounds me. Hey, Dr. Coons. I'm Kathy Hunnell. I'm a reading coach at DuPont Elementary School. I've been here since year 2000. Here at DuPont, we value literacy and all of our families. For many years, we have participated in One School, One Book. This is a time of year where every teacher, every student, every family, and other staff members all read the same book over the same days. One School One Book helps our students and families understand that

[03:17:04] everyone can enjoy reading aloud a great book. At school during these days of reading, daily trivia questions are asked over morning announcements for classes to discuss. Prizes are given each day for correct trivia responses. These discussions and prizes create an atmosphere of excitement.

[03:17:23] there's common chatter and talk all about amazing books and characters. We truly love literacy and we love our families and it's a great time of year. Hi, I'm Ms. Freeman and I am the school counselor here for grades three through five at DuPont. Hi, I am Whitney Foster. I am the school counselor here at DuPont for grades K through two. Hi, I am Jennifer Williams. I am the truancy officer at the elementary level and i am representing Dupont today as a member of the attendance team

[03:17:56] we strive to improve attendance and student awareness of how important it is to attend school in addition to student awareness we have strived to increase parent awareness and engagement as well our students struggled to come to school we had very low attendance rates and so as an attendance team we tried to build up to see what we could do um it looks like in the year of 2023 our numbers look at about 39.38 of students who had um below 90 percent of attendance uh we are

[03:18:32] now at 27.87 um so one of the strategies that we found to work very well with our students are challenges that occur each month um so we give students challenges for them to come to school every day and give them some sort of incentive or prize for all those students who have perfect attendance for that month. Additionally, we hold attendance assemblies similar to pep rallies, and we recognize students who, again, attended school every day for the month. Each month is something a little bit different. Sometimes it's a word search. Sometimes it is a puzzle, coloring,

[03:19:11] things of that sort, just to keep the students engaged. And I think another big thing for our attendance is really showcasing it this year we have lanyards not only for students but for staff and they receive brag tags just being able to see them wear their lanyards with so much pride and earning brag tags for something simple as coming to school something simple as allowing their parents to come with them to any events that we may have whether it be after school whether it be um our hispanic heritage event or parent teacher conference students will earn brag

[03:19:46] tags just for simply showing up. And so I think with them being able to know that, it gives them that pride. So there you have it. Our students are eager to learn and grow. We build meaningful and loving relationships with them using research and science-based tools, which then allow our babies to build the confidence and self-worth to grow not only academically, but emotionally.

[03:20:14] it can be done. High expectations and a culture of care will make the difference for all of the Commonwealth's children. Thank you for the opportunity to highlight our amazing school

[03:20:28] in Hopewell. Last month several of you asked us to bring you examples and models and so we wanted

[03:22:05] to give you some samples of school divisions, schools that are breaking barriers and using state and local resources and really thinking intentionally to give you some of the things that we're working on. I know Brad talked about communities in schools, engagement, home visits.

[03:22:23] I knew DuPont talked about parent engagement, recognizing attendance. I know we've talked about Zearn. We've talked about literacy networks, supporting teachers, mentoring. You heard a lot of those concrete strategies that are happening across the state to really dig in and change performance.

[03:22:40] I am happy if you want to ask questions, if you want to come back up and ask questions. Does that sound right? Okay, great. You guys aren't off the hook yet.

[03:23:22] Before I open it up to anybody else who has questions, I just want to say thank you to you all. We know this is hard work, and we are so proud of your commitment to hard work. You are shining stars to this profession and shining stars to the students you serve every single day in modeling what hard work helps us all achieve together. So I can't thank you enough.

[03:23:52] I love to be able to see that just this really broad cross-section of rural and urban to give everyone the feeling that it doesn't matter whether you teach or you're a leader, sorry, this thing's kind of funky uh in a title one school or whether you have amazing amounts of resources at your fingertips you guys are showing us that you can achieve so many things and it

[03:24:26] doesn't absolutely depend on more and more and more and more physical dollars it's also about how you innovate how you think creatively outside of the box to engage the resources you have and The one thing that I heard over and over from you all is the value you place in your human resources.

[03:24:49] That above all else, showing our teachers not only can we help our students achieve, but we can help our teachers achieve whatever they want to achieve themselves by giving the professional resources to them that they so desperately want to have to help their students be the most successful that they can be. So before I get teary-eyed and all kinds of emotional here, I just want to say thank you. And no, I know you hear it from your own communities

[03:25:26] all the time, the difference that you're making, but I thank you from the bottom of my heart for the difference that you are making for not only the students in your schools and school divisions, but also for the example that you're setting to those in the remainder of the Commonwealth that are watching this today.

[03:25:45] So thank you so much. Madam Chairman. Sure, if you all wouldn't mind, I know we might have some specific questions for you. So if you wouldn't mind just coming all up to the front and you can have a mic, because I don't know if this microphone is working or not.

[03:26:07] Kevin, is that one working? Okay, that's fine. We can flip that thing around.

[03:26:29] Now we can run back up here. Okay. Are there questions or comments from the board, Ms. Kilgore?

[03:26:46] I wanted to echo your comments and say that I got teary-eyed sitting there, and it made me almost want to come out of retirement and go back into the classroom. I could feel the passion that each and every one of you had for your school and your school system.

[03:27:02] And I know we have many, many, many people in our state who share that same passion that you do, but it was very, very much appreciated and very inspirational. So thank each of you for what you're doing for our students. And I like whoever said our babies, because even though I taught high school, I always call them my babies.

[03:27:20] So thank you all very much. And it was also kind of nice to hear two guys talking kind of like I do. So that's refreshing. Dr. Northern? So these may be for the schools that are dealing with the older kids.

[03:27:37] There's a conversation nationally really around, you know, tough love or not. And I feel like I heard a lot of culture of caring, which absolutely key. But I'm wondering for the older kids, again, of which I taught once upon a time, some places have put in policies like the kids have to make up the time if they miss, like they have to come after school or they have to come to Saturday school or they have to come to detention or if you miss a certain number of days, you can't pass a class.

[03:28:07] So I'm wondering the folks who are dealing with the older kids, whether you see any space for more of a tough love approach or whether you think that it's, that that's not going to work or just how do you think about the differences between how to handle chronic absenteeism at the early grades versus the later grades?

[03:28:32] we can probably all speak to um i know for us um yes the the tough love our kids know our students know we love on them we want them to be successful and beyond brunswick county um but one of the things we do that as well if students um particularly our high school students because that's where we were struggling initially with the chronic absenteeism and um we've done pretty well this past year with all of the support from the state um but for those students you miss a day

[03:29:03] We're calling your house immediately. Sometimes we're a small community as well. So one of our directors or someone from transportation will show up at your house to get you to school. But you're going to make that time up because we love you enough to make you come to school and encourage you to come in. So you're going to make that time up for school after school. We have Saturday schools where we'll come. We'll pick you up. We're going to pick you up. We're going to feed you. So we're loving on you. But you need to be there to make up your time and get your instruction done.

[03:29:30] And I would just add to what Christy said, you know, tough love, I think, over my 40-year career has kind of a negative connotation. It's kind of like a one and done. You either respond to this consequence or we're going to be really tough on you.

[03:29:48] And sometimes that has translated to give up on you. So I think that what collectively, what my guess is we would all say is that natural consequences are real. And that doesn't have to be negative. It's just if we do this, this is going to happen.

[03:30:03] So my guess is that all of us have embraced maybe not such a tough perspective, you know, the connotation that is associated with that. But just as Christy beautifully said, we love you enough that we're not going to accept this less than the best and less than excellence.

[03:30:20] And so whatever it takes, we're going to do that. And you are going to, you know, there are consequences to this, but we're still in this game with you and we're not giving up ever. So hope that helps. We do have a statewide program that allows schools to make up time. So if a student comes for additional time, they can recount that. So we do have a statewide incentive to ensure that we have kiddos coming back into the school if they miss.

[03:30:46] Madam President, anyone else want to make a comment about that question before we move on? Okay. I don't know. But I just I know that my experience is primarily elementary up through middle school. But speaking from the instructional standpoint, I also think that we have to think about the the engagement and the opportunities that we provide our students and making sure that our students want to come to school.

[03:31:13] And so they have that yearning to want to learn because, hey, I'm going to go to school today because I want to see what Ms. Bianca was going to teach in her classroom because I know it's going to be amazing. And so I think a lot of it goes along with the engagement that we provide, the lessons that we create for our students and building that rapport and that relationship so that our students want to come to school, whether they're our tiniest babies, which I still see my tiny babies that I had when I used to visit them at kindergarten, first grade. I see them now in high school. I still get hugs and loves and there's Miss B because they want to come to school.

[03:31:49] They want to be engaged and they want to learn. And so I think, you know, instructionally, that's something that we have to focus on as far as attendance to, you know, what we're providing for them speaks to whether or not they're even at that high school age or secondary age, whether they want to come or not. And that engagement still needs to be there at that secondary level, just like it is at the elementary level. Dr. Bryce. Thanks. First, I just want to thank you all for sharing your time with us today. I want to commend you for your accomplishments. I was

[03:32:23] struck by each of you have such a humility about this, like you're here to be recognized for your successes and not a single one of you took credit for it yourself. So you gave credit to your teachers and the families and the students. So it's a great example for all of us. I wanted to ask about parental involvement. So I think it was in the video you talked about, we know that students who have involved parents are more likely to have academic success. I loved in the video seeing so many parents in the school. What about the students who don't have that, who don't have

[03:33:01] the benefit of parental involvement. What roles can schools play, can teachers play to make up for that difference? Because we know that it is a huge difference. We actually have been dealing with that a bit. We have exhibitions where the students get to showcase their work and they're super excited about it. And sometimes parents have to work or there's a single parent and they have to do something else. We have a really great community where other parents step up and step in. So you

[03:33:39] see that one baby just sitting there waiting, you know, looking at every single person that comes in and every time someone recognizes that and will go and say, hey, what did you do? Tell me about your project. And this year we intentionally asked teachers to invite parents in. Parents are intimidated to come into school, especially where we are. We're always telling them what their child is doing wrong, what

they can't do. Just welcome them in and let's see what it looks like just for a day. Come for an experiment. Come help. And seeing the parents just come and sometimes they're

[03:34:15] just standing back, but to see them engage not only again with their child, but the other children that might not have the parent that, that is there. So not only do the community and the other parents step up, but we'll get a call on the walkie. Hey, come to this classroom and check this out. Or such and such doesn't have someone, mom called at the last minute. And I'll go into a classroom and seek that student out. And it's, it's just the culture of what we do. It's just what we do. I would just add one more thing from the district level. We have years ago recognized,

[03:34:52] especially in communities of high poverty, that the old-fashioned sort of spaghetti dinner with a book and maybe even a little concert gets parents to come to school, but it's the same parents. And it's not always, it's actually often not the parents that we need to be better and more strategically engaging with. So it's been a long challenge and we continue to, it's still a work in progress. But what we've learned is that we've got to take that engagement to them in their communities, in their comfort zones. And it doesn't look the same anymore. We've hired a family

[03:35:30] engagement liaisons at a time when we don't have any local money to dedicate to additional human resources. But we said we've got to have boots on the ground that can go and knock on doors and talk to people and develop relationships that start the process to make them more comfortable to the reality that Ms. Lobo indicated that school sometimes is kind of scary and our parents don't feel competent and at the highest capacity. So anyway, I think learning that we have to take it to them and make it what they need and where they need it. Big difference

[03:36:07] in a public housing project in their community center than the, you know, office or the auditorium of the elementary school. Huge difference in comfort level and just a willingness to come together for our mutual purpose and goals. So rethinking that. Ms. McPherson. I'm sorry. I thought I may add too to that and more for my time too, both now and as a principal, but I think it's actually letting every parent know that you know them and whether it be a parent, a guardian,

[03:36:41] whoever has care of that child. And one thing during my principalship at JW Adams in Wise County, And I think that we knew every parent and every kid. And one thing that I challenged our teachers to do was to make a positive contact with every household before early on in the year.

[03:37:01] And then I told our teachers that one expectation I have of you is that if a kid comes down for a discipline referral and it's not an emergency, I'd like to have a log that you've actually tried to make contact a couple of times first. And you kind of invest in that relationship.

[03:37:19] And when we talk to people as individuals with no pretense that we're not, that we're just kind of, that they, we put down barriers around them. It makes it much more that they're able to come into our schools and feel like they're instantly accepted and that we're talking as human beings to one another.

[03:37:35] And I do think that approach works. You know, I was really proud, you know, JW got to be a National Title I Distinguished School. It was a National Blue Ribbon School. And there's high poverty in that community, too. But now it does take time and it's an investment. it got to the point that the community loved that school and wanted to see us succeed and i think that's the model you know that it it's an investment though that to get those parents there miss mcpherson jerry field reminded us of how kids are and how endearing and adorable they can be

[03:38:16] uh i wanted to just go back quickly to the issue about the data collection could you just let me know maybe how often the teachers are updated on um the absenteeism or the collection of data and you know what you're doing to you know update them just um any of us yeah how often are you involving them in that process so that they see the data and can react to it well i'll speak to the chronic absenteeism piece and i'll let bianca speak to the uh instructional data but for the The chronic absenteeism piece, and if I could tell you a very short story, I'll be quick.

[03:38:53] One of the things we realized when we were looking at the data, probably we had always looked at the absenteeism data, but really looking at it with a fine tooth comb. One of the things that I did a solution circle at the VAS conference, and I brought it forth and said, hey, I'm not really sure I know this data.

[03:39:12] I don't know if principals are engaged enough in this data for chronic absenteeism. And, you know, when they did their solution circle, they had an opportunity to kind of discuss. They said, well, that's great. She knows her data, but how is she making sure that her principals and the teachers know that data? So every week we actually meet with, we have a standing meeting with our principals, attendance clerks, and then those principals take that information and start working with the teachers on it.

[03:39:39] But we look at every single student. And while we recognize with being small, that gives us a little bit of an advantage. We have less than 1,500 students, but we look at every single student because we wanted to make sure we knew those children. So if Sean's not coming to school, then we want to know why Sean's not coming to school. Have you met with Sean? Has anybody taken his time to speak with him? Have we spoken to his parents and see what's going on? What's going on in his classes? Because sometimes just meeting with that student, you'll get more insight, like Ms. Bianco said about the engagement piece. We would get information from students that would say, high school students, 90-minute class,

[03:40:15] I taught high school. I get it. You know, and if they're not engaged for that 90 minutes, they may say, hey, I don't like three of my four classes. I'm not coming to school today. I'm not going to bother with it. So really that helped us on the instructional end, but it helped the administration and the teachers to really get to know each and every one of those students and what their needs were so that, you know, we could identify, hey, what's, this is what's happening with the student and be able to address it or even be a bit more proactive in looking at hey Sean seems a little bit different today you know something's going on with him let's see what's what's happening because it could be something going on at home it could

[03:40:53] be something going on with him emotionally or academically and just addressing that student ahead of time so for us really just looking at looking at that data every single week and we have a standing meeting every Thursday and we we look at that data as a division well I know that we thank you all so much i know that we um gave you guys kind of a time commitment here and i think we are run up on that time so i'm so sorry that we're run we have run over because we could if if you can do it very quickly because we promised them that they could be out of here

[03:41:30] at 12 30. if you if you have time i would just love to ask thank you thank you i'll echo the the amazing work you're doing we're so grateful what more do you need from us the board the department the commonwealth to be able to continue the great work you're doing and making improvements particularly you know the all-in funding as you know time limit what what what what what can we do to help you do the right work you're doing so involved go ahead this might surprise you

[03:42:06] um i i'm betting i can speak for everybody here because we're small and don't have any money so it's not money for me i mean it really isn't money it's important but it's it is flexibility and uh i said earlier i've been here a long time and she knows this jeremy knows this i've told them both personally um i've been through a lot of state superintendents and administrations and governors um i feel at this point in time we are so respected and so appreciated and our voices

[03:42:42] matter and uh so and just the question the nature of the question uh it reinforces that for me it it's flexibility we have to do things differently and that i think is what makes every one of these people and schools and districts represented today so successful is that we've given one one of you said it, the opportunity to speak out, to step outside of the box and innovate and be creative. We trust, to the first issue earlier, we trust the vetting that is done here to the textbooks. I'm signing up for the only one because we trust the work that you all have done

[03:43:21] and we are in partnership constantly. And I did not plan for that question nor to make this political, but we are grateful for all the funds that you have. We know they're not limitless. But for us, it's the ability to get creative and think outside of the box. We need alternative routes to licensure because we can't find teachers. One in three teachers in Hopewell, with all the success that has happened in DuPont, one in three is not even provisionally licensed.

[03:43:47] They have a bachelor's degree in something. The rest is our job and as quickly as we can possibly do it. So flexibility, understanding of what's uniquely different and the ability to program to that even when it may be radically crazy and not so traditional is what we continue to need and hope well. Thank you for that. She said it beautifully. Well, again, we were truly honored today to have you all here with us to talk about the amazing things that you all are doing and will

[03:44:24] continue to do. And I can tell that all of you have the heart and the desire when you are gone and decide that it's time to retire, that you all are training up good leaders to take your place and to carry on the heart and soul of where you all are today. So thank you so much for the time that you've given us today, but moreover the time and the heart and soul that you give to the kids of each one of your school divisions. So thank you. And with that, I'm not going to belabor

[03:45:03] the other point, which is for us to have a break for lunch. So I think we will break for lunch

[03:45:13] until 1.30ish. Okay. Thank you. This afternoon, we are back and ready to begin our afternoon

[04:43:06] presentations uh this afternoon we are going to hear from m cooper on a update on the assessment rfi you all should have printed in front of you a copy of this presentation and i believe is it correct that it is online for those in the public to see as well so thank you very much take it away miss cooper good afternoon everyone i am here to provide an update on the request for information for Virginia's assessment system. Pursuant to item 119A of chapter 2, 2024 Acts of

[04:43:45] the General Assembly, the department shall include in its annual report a plan to implement a new state assessment system, including a revised time frame, estimated short and long-term costs, including the costs to transition to the new system, staffing and training needs, key milestones, and project deliverables. The department shall request the funding needed to implement the new contract for inclusion in the governor's introduced budget bill for the 2025 regular session.

[04:44:15] The department may consider issuing a request for information, which is an RFI, as part of the process to better determine the costs and requirements of the new system. The department shall submit

the annual report no later than November 1st, 2024. On slide three, you'll see that based on the General Assembly's directive, VDOE issued a request for information for the new assessment vendors as part of the process to better determine the costs and requirements of the new system. Recommendations were provided from various stakeholders, including parents,

[04:44:52] educators, school and division leaders, superintendents, and national experts. On the next slide, you'll see that we're here to clarify some information around the RFIs. I know there's been some confusion. So I want to make sure that we're all on the same page about what an RFI is and is not. So to be clear, the VDOE issued an RFI. The purpose is to gain understanding about the capacity vendors have to meet the needs of the work and the unique context of the

[04:45:25] organization or new or innovative concepts issued at the beginning of a project. The information learned helps the organization drive the development of a more detailed approach and then sets requirements to set the project up for success. This is not a legally binding process and the legislation asked for an RFI to be issued. To be clear, we did not issue a request for proposal.

[04:45:52] An RFP is a process used when an organization already has a clear set of requirements needed for a project and they're ready to make a purchase by a vendor who meets those requirements. This is a formal bid process, which includes evaluating proposals using a numerical scoring system, which then generates a selected vendor in which a contract will be initiated.

[04:46:15] VDOE issued a request for information to identify vendors who have implemented statewide comprehensive assessment systems similar to the size of Virginia to determine if the marketplace has vendors that can meet the goals of the assessment program and the recommendations that were in the House Bill 585 report. On slide five, to see if the market had capacity, the RFI sought to gain information aligned to the recommendations of the House Bill 585 work group and feedback from the field. The RFI asked vendors to provide

[04:46:53] information in these categories. The first category is rigorous assessment item development. So this is ensuring that a vendor can develop rigorous assessment questions aligned to the Virginia Standards of Learning. Two, developing a test that allows students to demonstrate their knowledge in various ways and provides accessibility features for all learners.

[04:47:17] Three, reporting that is easy to understand by various audiences and is provided in a timely manner. Four, a coherent assessment system that measures proficiency and growth in grades K through 12. Five, producing competency-based assessments that are available during the school year. Six, providing performance tasks measuring Virginia's five C's in fifth and eighth grade. And then seven, a cost for all of those components. An eighth category will be included in the report on teacher training after the vendors were asked a follow-up question on how they will support educators in the

[04:47:55] assessment system. On slide six, you'll see the department released the assessment RFI on August 26th, and it closed on September 30th. There were six vendors who submitted RFI responses by the deadline. The VDOE reviewed each proposal to identify vendors who have implemented statewide comprehensive assessment systems similar to the size of Virginia, providing strong, adequate, or incomplete answers for all of the criteria outlined in the RFI. The VDOE reviewed each

[04:48:29] proposal to identify vendors who had met that criteria. Only four responses of those six vendors had enough information to complete an analysis of their ability to meet the criteria, and those

vendors were Cambium, Data Recognition Corporation, or DRC, Numerity, and Pearson. On the next slides, i'll share a summary of the submissions from each vendor for each of those recommendations an indication of strong adequate or incomplete is also listed to show how much information was provided by those vendors and this will help us understand if the market is rich in each of those

[04:49:08] categories the first component requested information on the experience and proposal for creating virginia specific assessment questions aligned to the standards of learning integrating various item types beyond multiple choice. You can see here examples of how each vendor responded to this portion of the RFI, and two vendors had strong evidence that this is possible. Two vendors had less evidence, including DRC, who did not include a cost estimate for this

[04:49:40] item. I think you mean category, not item, right? Sorry, yes. Okay. For the next category included the rfi was test development so on the next slide you'll see how those vendors responded a critical step in implementation of new standards and the development of the new assessment types is the ability for states to have enough items in their item bank to test all of the standards alignment of test items to the new standards and that the state provides divisions with field test items

[04:50:14] and the release of items for teachers and students to use and have experience with prior for the actual assessment being given. There were three vendors that had strong evidence here, so we're confident that the market can support Virginia's need in test development. On the next slide, you'll see, and as you know, we've received feedback on the difficulties in reporting and BDOE has worked hard to improve them. User-friendly reports are very important to families and educators, so you can see examples here from two vendors that showed strong evidence for timely,

[04:50:50] clear, and actionable reporting. On the next slide for improving system coherence, as a reminder, Virginia's assessment system includes end-of-year assessments and then growth assessments, and improving coherence of the system will ensure high-quality aligned assessments are administered to students. The market looks strong here as three vendors provided evidence in this category. On the next slide, you'll see competency-based assessments, and as we've been discussing over the past few months, these allow students to be assessed when they are ready.

[04:51:30] This area was a challenge in the market as vendors were less comfortable here and there was less evidence provided. Next, you'll see performance tasks. So aligned to our three framework tasks will be given in fifth and eighth grade, a measure of Virginia's five C's and the career exploration and academic planning for middle school. So here you'll see that there are vendors with evidence in developing performance tasks. The next slide, you'll see budget. So vendors were asked to submit a pricing sheet for each component of the RFI as part of their

[04:52:10] proposal. One vendor submitted a completing pricing sheet, two submitted a pricing sheet that had some items blank, and DRC did not submit a pricing sheet even upon a follow-up request. Next, you'll see some teacher training responses. So we know that our teachers need training, they need release test items, and more opportunities to understand the assessment.

[04:52:35] I know Superintendent Kuhns has talked with VA and they have expressed how much they want these supports for teachers as well, and so we asked all four vendors a follow up question around teacher trainings to see what can they provide. And you could see that all four provided adequate evidence here if we move forward we'll have to work towards better resources and trainings for our teachers and leaders.

[04:52:58] On the next slide you'll see a summary of evidence for each of the eight categories by vendor. We have two vendors and the areas of test development and system coherence with mostly strong evidence indicating a good market for an improved assessment system in Virginia.

[04:53:17] And then lastly, you'll see some next steps. This information shows that there are providers that have the capacity to meet the expectations of an RFP process and meet the intended threshold of the required RFI. The information will be used to create a full report that will explain the capacity and interest of those assessment providers to meet the full needs of our assessment system.

[04:53:41] The report will be submitted to the General Assembly November 1st and then shared with the governor's office and the board. And then in addition, the information from the RFI will inform the House Bill 585 report update that will be submitted to the General Assembly on November first as well. And you all in the governor's office will receive that report too. Thank you.

[04:54:06] Questions, comments? Dr. Northern? I'm just wondering if as part of the process, and I know you guys will reach out to states that are actually using each of these vendors, is that reflected yet in this information or will that, when do you build in the process for reaching out to states and hearing how it's going with those vendors? We have to use a formal procurement process. So we can definitely, if moved forward, ask for reference sheets and

[04:54:33] reference reference comments as part of the procurement. But an RFP of this size is considered a high risk RFP. So there are very specific statutory guidelines that would require us to be followed in that process. Other questions, comments, Ms. Holton? This is very useful. Thank you. Can you help us understand? You've given us the next steps up through the November 1st report, but help us understand what happens after that.

[04:55:07] And I'm particularly interested in when and how there will be an opportunity for stakeholder engagements, particularly the assessment coordinators in the divisions who obviously have a lot of expertise on this. Where do they get to weigh in before or during an RFP process?

[04:55:31] Dr. Gaines? Yeah. Member Holton, I think one of the biggest parts of this process that informed the categories was the House Bill 585 and the work that was extensive in getting stakeholder support, stakeholder feedback, stakeholder priorities. As part of the RFI process, we had to take the advice from the field and the advice from that report and see if the capacity was there, which was the RFI process. So that stakeholder input was part of what was used for those categories that M presented on. But in other words, the hope is that this leads to, well, this will lead to

[04:56:05] some kind of RFP process. We don't know. Yeah. What will the RFP process look like? Our current test contract expires unless it's otherwise extended in June of 25. Am I right? I would have to check. So what's the process? It expires. Well, Ms. Cooper knows when it expires. Maybe you can tell us, but what's the process for an RFP and what opportunity for stakeholder engagement is there? We don't have the finance team here, but we have been notified that this is a high-risk procurement because of the amount of the contract and the amount of the RFP. We will have to follow

[04:56:44] very specific processes that are required as part of that RFP process. And do those include I cannot speak to that. I would have to have a finance person and a legal person here to answer that question. Okay. I have another question if I'm going to move on. Do you want to say something?

[04:57:03] A whole lot of that I can shed on the high-risk contract process, but I don't know whether it does undergo reviews both by either or both EGS and VEDA. This is probably a new contract, I'm guessing, is what they've decided.

[04:57:19] So they will be looking at, it also undergoes a process of review in our office, both at the RFP and at the contracting state. Both those reviews take place at both feet. Those reviews are important. What I think the stakeholder engagement would be important on absolutely is the issues the 585 task force looked at, but that was some time ago now and without these specifics on the table.

[04:57:45] So I hope that the department will look for an opportunity to engage our stakeholders in what's substantively going to be improved. What are the opportunities to improve upon our current assessment system through this process?

[04:58:01] I mean, particularly, I'm interested in, are we getting better? Are we looking at better growth measures? Are we going to finally have a growth measure that works for more grade levels, for instance? Are we going to have growth information quickly back to schools?

[04:58:17] Are we going to be able to do growth and proficiency assessments in a way that are less intrusive to the educational process, less time, more bang for our buck? Those kinds of, you know, the assessment coordinators don't need to be involved in the discussion of whether which vendor has met legal requirements or maybe even in the finances may not be their input, but what's it going to look like?

[04:58:50] And do different companies, different providers, are they offering us some different options that may be useful, relatively more or less useful to the division? How do we get that input? Yeah, I will say the first part of your comment slash question that was deeply discussed in the 585 work group and Dr. Northern was also a part of that work group and can validate my comments there.

[04:59:18] I do think that we have a mighty robust report that came out of that work group that certainly informed this process very deeply. And I mean, we had a very, very large work group that was put together that did the work of the 585 that was that was required of 585.

[04:59:42] And so I would certainly challenge you to take this information and look at that particular document that came out of the work group. And certainly I'd be more than happy to entertain anything that you see as differences there.

[04:59:59] Well, I mean, I have read it. I read it when it came out. I don't remember whether it was a year ago or two years ago, frankly, but it's been quite some time and was without the specifics that, I mean, part of the whole RFI process, I think I understood was to ask providers what's possible.

[05:00:16] And then to now, having gotten to now, between knowing what's possible and what do we contract for, seems like an opportunity when we would want to go back to either reconvene the task force or otherwise reach out to our stakeholders.

[05:00:33] This is really important stuff, and we have a testing system. I'm so sorry we don't have Dr. Siebert here, but who understands this better than I do, certainly, and helped us understand that our current testing system is extremely antiquated, and this is our opportunity to move to a, you know, in the next seven-year contract, how is this new system going to be better for teachers and principals?

[05:00:57] How's it going to get them better data in a less intrusive way to help improve student outcomes? And I think I saw in the newspaper that there's going to be a big ask to the General Assembly to

increase the spending on this. What are we getting for our, what bang for our buck are we getting?

[05:01:15] That ought to be a discussion that's not just lawyers and finance people. It ought to be a much more robust discussion. I'm unclear what the question is. Was the question, when are we going to get to do this? was the question about the newspaper article that was inaccurate, was the question about the RFP process. If you help me with which question you would like me to answer, I'm happy to do that. I think my whole question is about what is the, well, I'll rephrase it. What are the opportunities for stakeholder and board involvement in the process going forward from

[05:01:51] November 1st until we have a new testing contract in place. Thank you. Thank you for the clarity. I will refer you to page four, which is the RFI, which was based on the October 1, 2023 House Bill 585 report, which when the RFI was developed was six to eight months old. As you can see, an RFI is to gain an understanding of vendor process. This is a summary and a high-level summary to keep the board engaged in the process we have not started the rfp process nor are we in

[05:02:28] the next steps of an rfp process which is in your slide deck in your slide deck you will note a summary of the high level responses which were received last week the full report which will give you some of those questions about what they provided in hundreds and hundreds of pages in response to an rfi on november 1st once we have that we can further discuss some of the next steps that you're requesting thank you i didn't hear an answer about whether there will be further opportunity for either the board or stakeholders to engage in the process between now and when an

[05:03:02] rfp a new contract is finalized we have not had that opportunity to even discuss that process because we are currently in the process of analyzing the details of the report and providing a nova remember first i'd be happy to bring an update to the december meeting with your request i would appreciate that thank you um mr rothering thank you madam president i just want to make sure i'm tracking this we should we are safe in assuming this was an rfi so this was vendors who decided this was important enough to them to give the amount dr coons of information that that

[05:03:37] you just described we should not assume that once an rfp actually goes out that this is the universe of vendors who might respond or to miss holton's point the universe of approaches we might see and all of that is that that that sounds like a statement it's a question is that an accurate summation yeah the intent of an rfi is to see the capacity of the marketplace and understand that the capacity of the marketplace can even meet our hopes and dreams that came out of the 585 report anything further so so i think one thing i mean and i don't

[05:04:12] know if like this is the opportunity for us to engage on hey maybe we ought to talk about going a step further when we get to the full rfp if we want to hold those thoughts or not but i was just thinking about how you guys referenced your request about teacher training and follow-up responses there and you know i think when we talk about how we want to have actionable data that's transparent and understanding or understandable to you know all of our different stakeholder groups that are going to engage in this data um are going to be you know wanting to understand how

[05:04:49] parents particularly want to understand how their child is doing how they performed um are we going to be able to ask for opportunities for some level of family training to say hey this is what you know you're used to you're used to this test we're moving from simply a multiple choice full test to a you know to have these performance tasks to have other opportunities open-ended questions that students will be responsive to that'll be graded just like they were on their straight multiple

[05:05:27] choice sol tests um because i do think that while we can inform and engage and train the educators in the room it's just as important to completing the circle to ensure that parents and families are fully aware of well gosh my kid took an sol last year what is this this still the sol i don't you know are they going to have to take another test too you know i just think that there's a lot of communication and education that needs to happen as we move through this process that we need to be extremely deliberate and intentional about so um maybe that's something that we want

[05:06:06] to add to to ensuring that vendors are capable of of providing that support too i think we've talked before on a different level on some different types of assessments that we use about how we train teachers to communicate with parents on what these tests mean.

[05:06:32] I know we talked about MAPS testing before and how we need to sort of create a system where it's just an expectation that teachers know and are capable of having conversations with parents and families that here is what this test means here is what your child's score means and how we move the goalposts together so i just want to say all of that so that we're really seeing this holistically as broadly as we possibly can it's great feedback thank you

[05:07:12] Madam President, Dr. Bryce, along those lines, as we're asking vendors, you know, how they've done this work in other states, I think we should be asking specifically with the, you know, timely, clear and actionable reporting, how are they doing? How have they successfully reported this to families? And have they seen better engagement, like better understanding from families with what they've done in other states? I would be particularly interested in seeing that.

[05:07:47] Thank you, Jim. Other comments, questions? Em, do we overwhelm you? Never. So good to know. Next time we'll step it up. Okay, I appreciate that. We have one additional.

[05:08:07] Thank you so much, Em. We are expecting our final presentation here shortly. Oh, I'm sorry.

[05:08:19] So, if we could just take like a 5-10 minute break to go use the restroom and take care of our other needs. Let's do that, please. Thank you.

[05:16:34] Okay, good afternoon. We're back. It is my distinct honor this afternoon to begin our discussion on item C, National Best Practice Series, which is today going to be headlined by Dr. Tom Cain around supporting accountability.

[05:35:43] Dr. Cain is an economist and Walter H. Gale professor of education at the Harvard School of Education. He is faculty director of the Center for Education Policy Research, a university-wide research center that works with school districts and state agencies.

[05:36:01] Between 2009 and 2012, he directed Measures of Effective Teaching Project for the Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation. His work has spanned both K-12 and higher education, covering topics such as the design of school accountability systems, teacher recruitment and retention, financial aid for college, race-conscious college admissions, and the earnings impact of community colleges.

[05:36:26] From 1995 to 1996, Dr. Cain served as a senior economist for labor education and welfare policy Institutes within President Clinton's Council of Economic Advisors. From 1991 through 2000, he was a faculty member at the Kennedy School of Government. Dr. Cain has also been a professor of public policy at UCLA and has held visiting fellowships at the Brookings Institute and at the Hoover Institution at

Stanford University. Dr. Cain's presentation for the board members is in your email and additionally has been loaded to the SharePoint site and is available

[05:37:05] to the public on our website. It is a distinct honor and wonderful pleasure to have you here with us today, Dr. Cain, and we are so thankful for you coming to kick us off on this series that we are going to be working through as a board in our discussions moving forward. So we thank you so much for being with us today. Well, thank you, Chair Creasy. For the generous introduction, thing that wasn't in the introduction is that I grew up about 220 miles southeast of here

[05:37:43] in Winston-Salem, North Carolina. And my oldest brother, I have three brothers and a sister, but my oldest brother worked for Norfolk and Southern Railroad and lived in Roanoke and Norfolk for many years and i have a niece and nephew that both graduated from uba so um so i i even though i've never lived in richmond i feel like i i have some familiarity with the virginia well hopefully we will provide you a warm welcome back to this wonderful region of the mid-atlantic states so

[05:38:22] thank you so i i i am going to go through the slides um uh so i'm so are folks currently looking at a slide deck where the first slide says resuming progress in virginia schools yes yeah okay so let's let's page down to the next slide so um everything almost everything that i'll be talking about today is drawn from research reports that are on this education recoveryscorecard.org website. At that website, what we've done is we've taken all of the state

[05:38:59] test score results by district in states around the country and put them on the NAEP scale, the National Assessment of Educational Progress scale, to make it comparable so that we could compare what was happening in terms of achievement losses in different districts around the country.

[05:39:20] So it's possible to compare what happened in Richmond to what happened in New Haven, Connecticut, or St. Louis, Missouri, or other districts in Massachusetts. So in the first section, I want to talk about just the role of school closures in terms of achievement gap widening.

[05:39:45] So the next slide is, so low-income schools around the country remained closed longer than middle and higher-income schools. Now, within, obviously, different states had different policies about how long schools remain closed during the 2021 school year.

[05:40:11] But in every state, higher poverty schools tended to stay out for longer. So, for instance, in the top group of states in terms of length of closures, Virginia's in that group, there was about a nine-week difference in average days closed for high and low poverty districts.

[05:40:34] Next slide, though, is low-income schools lost more per week of closure than higher income schools. The thing to notice on the left-hand side of this slide is that in areas that opened back up fairly quickly during the 2021 school year, everybody lost ground, but everybody lost about the same amount of ground, that the blue, the red, and the orange lines are all fairly close to each other, that everybody lost about 20% of a school year if you

[05:41:13] reopened pretty quickly during 2021. And remember, almost everybody was out in the spring of 2020. So even if people came back right away in the fall of 2020, people had, there was ground that districts had lost. But as you move to the right in this graph, as you, the longer the schools were closed, there were bigger losses per week of closure for the higher poverty schools.

[05:41:44] So Horace Mann famously said, public schools are the balance wheel of the social machinery. We saw that in action during the pandemic because it was like a light switch when you close schools down. The losses per week of closure were larger for higher poverty schools.

[05:42:08] The next slide is just plotting the national trends in achievement. And you can see that there were large losses from 19 to 22.

[05:42:24] And then the initial recovery between 22 and 23 was about students covered about a third of the loss in math. So the total loss was about 0.54 grade equivalents in math, about 3.8 grade equivalents in reading.

[05:42:47] But, and they, so they made up about a third of that loss in math and about a quarter of the loss in reading. I've been just included here, relative to historical standards, that was a historically large improvement from 22 to 23.

[05:43:04] So it was about 170% as large as the typical annual growth during a period of pretty substantial growth between 1990 and 2013. And it was twice the annual growth rate in reading between 1990 and 2012, 2013.

[05:43:27] So it was large. It was just insufficient to help students catch up. Now, on the next slide, you can just see most states remain behind as of 23. So this is just reporting the changes in scores, in math, and in reading, in grade equivalents.

[05:43:53] So among the 30 states we were able to include in this table, Virginia had some of the largest losses. But only one state, Alabama, was back above 2019 levels in math.

[05:44:13] And there were a couple of three states that were back above 2019 levels in reading. But the point of this graph is that almost everybody as of spring 23 were still substantially behind their own scores in 2019. Next slide is just showing just the widening of the gaps.

[05:44:32] The losses were larger in higher poverty districts. So the 90 to 100 percent poor districts lost, you know, like 0.7 or so grade equivalents in math. The lowest poverty districts, the 0 to 10 percent free or reduced price lunch, lost, you know, about 0.3 grade equivalents in math.

[05:44:58] And then between 22 and 23, though, even though there were somewhat larger gains at the highest poverty districts, I think that was largely due to the ESSER funds were targeted heavily to the higher poverty districts, you can still see things are fairly even across except for that one category in the 90% to 100%, the other categories of schools had similar recovery.

[05:45:34] So there was a recovery, but all categories are still behind and the gaps remain wider than they were in 2019. I just want to make sure I'm clear in describing that. I'm not saying achievement is lower in higher poverty schools. I'm saying higher poverty schools have made less progress in returning to where they themselves were in 2019 than the lower poverty schools. So this is just saying achievement gaps have widened. This is nationally, but in a few slides, I'll show you

[05:46:11] what happened in Virginia, which is really striking. Okay, the next slide, we worked hard last year on what I called the $190 billion question, which is like, did the federal money have much impact on recovery? If you want to read the gory details, there's a report on that website I pointed out before. The bottom line, though, is that I think the evidence is pretty clear that the dollars did have an effect, but they had an effect about the same as a general

[05:46:51] revenue increase rather than a targeted program. So it was as if districts were given a lump sum of money that they could spend on lots of things, not just on academic catch-up. So those dollars did have an effect, but didn't have the same effect as a targeted, if those same dollars had been more targeted at academic recovery. Important to remember that when those packages were passed in March of 2021, nobody knew how big the achievement losses were going to be. Like there

[05:47:31] were a lot of us who were, you know, everybody who had a child in school at that time knew that students were going to lose some ground. But I think in March of 2021, there was still some optimism that maybe a week of remote school is 80% as effective as a regular week, and yet it was only after that that we discovered it wasn't and that the losses were going to be as large as they were. Okay, next, I just wanted to hit what I see as the four main barriers to faster recovery so

[05:48:08] far. So number one has been the rise in student absenteeism. So here, I'm not plotting, I didn't have time to plot the data for Virginia, but if you just look at in California, the percentage of students who are chronically absent by district has essentially doubled. So back in the 1819 school year, it would have been very, very few districts had, you know, a chronic absenteeism rate of 35% or more. There were some, but very few. But as you can see, there's a spike. There's

[05:48:47] a large group, you know, that must be Los Angeles. There's a, you know, a lot of students in districts where there were 35% or more absenteeism, so that rates, chronic absenteeism, so that the chronic absenteeism has essentially doubled since before the pandemic. And there is some evidence, although hopefully we'll be learning a lot more in the coming years, that the places with high chronic absenteeism are the ones that are making less progress in terms of helping students

[05:49:20] catch up. Okay, the next barrier I want to highlight is from the beginning of, from the very beginning of when students started to get back into school, parents have underestimated the impacts on students. So I'm just showing a couple of polls here, but there were a number of different polls that show basically the same story. That in August of 2022, only 43% of parents, or 43%

[05:49:55] of parents said, my child did not experience any learning loss. Another 48% acknowledged that students had lost some ground, but they were confident their students would catch up. Only nine percent of parents were concerned at that point, concerned or very concerned that their child had lost ground and will struggle to catch up. Similarly, other polls suggest, you know, 90-some percent of parents believe their child is at or above grade level. The reason why this

[05:50:28] matters is that it's hard for any superintendent to ask for difficult things like extending the school year if parents are under the impression that since schools are back in session, everything's back on track and their child is fine. Very concretely, here in Richmond, students in Richmond lost about a year and a half's worth of math achievement over the course of the pandemic.

[05:51:03] When I say that, I mean the magnitude of their losses was equivalent to what the amount of ground that students typically learn in a year and a half worth of school.

[05:51:19] Very large losses. And yet, you know, the superintendent immediately proposed increasing, lengthening the school year, got voted down by the school board, proposed again, got voted down again, eventually got some additional learning time in a couple of schools last year.

[05:51:38] But that just, I say this parent perception of the impact on their students is one of the most important barriers. And it's important that we be honest with parents about just the magnitude of losses or

else it's going to be hard for superintendents to do what they need to do to help students catch up.

[05:51:58] The third barrier, which really shows up when you start to look at the district-by-district losses and the recovery, is that 90% of the money was directed directly to school districts.

[05:52:16] And state departments of education and the federal government had very little leverage in coordinating district activity. So imagine if the federal government had said, we're not going to try to come up with a vaccine, we're just going to distribute the money to local public health departments and say, you guys figure it out in terms of the pandemic.

[05:52:47] We could all imagine what would have happened. Some public health departments would have figured it out and some wouldn't have. Well, that's exactly what played out in local areas, that some districts had more effective strategies in terms of managing student learning during the pandemic.

[05:53:08] And then, you know, we're able to put together better strategies for helping students catch up after the pandemic. So we see, for instance, in New Jersey, Union City, a high poverty district, is almost back to where they were in 2019.

[05:53:24] But other districts with, you know, similar or even lower levels of poverty, Patterson and New Brunswick, remain more than a grade level behind where they were. In North Carolina, Durham and Guilford County are close to back to where they were in 2019, where, you know, Charlotte-Mecklenburg remains almost a year behind.

[05:53:50] Same thing around the country. Indiana, Indianapolis is about half a grade level behind still, whereas Metropolitan Warren is almost two grade levels behind. Okay. And the fourth issue that I want to spend a little bit of time on that I've completely failed at communicating over these last two or three years, but I'm going to try again this afternoon because I think it's been one of the biggest challenges to mounting an effective recovery.

[05:54:26] And that is coming up with a realistic sense of what it's going to take to help students return to 2019 levels. So I'm just going to go through a plan on paper. This is a hypothetical plan where we're going to say, what percentage of students are you going to serve with different kinds of interventions?

[05:54:49] And we'll multiply it by what the pre-pandemic research suggested would have been the impact. If anything, this is going to overstay the likely impact because, as we all know, districts struggle implementing, especially during this period. So high-impact, high-intensity tutoring.

[05:55:13] Say, you know, the pre-pandemic research suggested you'd get about a year's worth of achievement gains from that. That would be 36 weeks at three sessions a week, so, you know, 108 sessions. Most districts that we worked with struggled to do more than 20 or 30 sessions per student, but let's say that we were able to provide true high intensity tutoring to 10% of students. That would be not a whole year because it's only 10% of students. It would be

[05:55:46] a year times 10%. So you get on an expectation about a 10th of a year's worth of improvement. And if you page down, but I used animations.

[05:56:04] If you guys are looking at the slides, you might have to like, if you put it in slideshow mode and page down, it'll show you the next line. So double-dose math is another strategy.

[05:56:20] Let's say we provided an extra period of math to 30% of students. The pre-pandemic research suggested you'd get about a half a year's worth of growth out of that. So let's just multiply through 30%

times half a year, 0.15 years.

[05:56:39] Let's say we did launch an unprecedented summer learning program. So where we got not 15 or 20%, which is the typical summer learning, but say we got 75% of kids to attend a summer learning program.

[05:56:55] Let's multiply. The pre-pandemic research suggests you get about a quarter of a year. Multiply that through. And then suppose on top of all that, we extended the school year by two and a half weeks. If you added all of that up, it would add up to half a year's worth of growth.

[05:57:15] No district that I'm aware of in the country is doing as intensive a set of interventions as this. And yet, given the magnitude of the losses Richmond faced, they'd have to do this level of intervention three years in a row in order to help students catch up.

[05:57:37] Just a clarifying question. The extended school year, that would mean 100% of the district would go for the extended school year, plus 75% of them would do summer school on top of that. Yes, right. And 30% doing double dose math and 10% of students getting full high dosage tutoring.

[05:57:59] And honestly, most school districts, instead of thinking about it this way, thought, what is a bigger summer learning program than we've ever run? What is the biggest high dosage tutoring program that I can think, imagine running, which is a different way of thinking about it than how big an effort will we have to launch in order for how many years in order to help students catch

[05:58:29] up. And it's that doing the math on the plans that has not been happening. Okay. Now, why don't I just shift to part three? Because I just start by just plotting over time the changes in scores in Virginia versus national in the National Assessment of Educational Progress. And as you

[05:59:00] see, after 1998, when the standards of learning not only were issued, but where there was the standard of learning tests were beginning to be administered in 98, you see, Virginia rose, you know, had been at about the national average and improved relative to the national average where Virginia stayed until around 2017. But as of 2022, Virginia was back at the national average

[05:59:40] in fourth grade math and just a little bit above the national average in eighth grade math. on the next slide this is reading um similar story that after 1998 um prior to 1998 at least in fourth grade fourth grade reading virginia was at about the national average rose up uh above i'm just plotting in the no child left behind period where you know obviously the rest of the country

[06:00:10] had accountability starting in 2020, 2002, 2003. The rest of the country is rising after that. And then beginning around 2017, there were losses in Virginia. Now, actually, Virginia is below, slightly below the national average in both fourth and eighth grade reading.

[06:00:35] now even more disturbing are the next couple of slides um so here if you just here i just plotted for three dis or six districts three um larger higher income suburban districts hanover county fairfax county loudon county and then three um higher poverty uh urban districts so richmond City, Roanoke City, Norfolk City, you see that starting in 2015, there was about a two-grade

[06:01:14] equivalent difference in average math achievement between Richmond and Hanover County. Even starting before the pandemic, though, between 2015 and 2019, that two-grade equivalent difference had expanded to about 3.3 grade equivalents, and then it expanded some more between 19 and 22.

[06:01:44] There was somewhat larger recovery in the higher poverty districts, 22, 23, but still as of 23, Richmond remained 3.7 grade equivalents below Hanover County. In the next slides, it's just showing you what, like, if we, in these, again, we've converted the math scores into the NAEP scale. But if you see 2015, obviously there was a, you know, higher percent for your reduced price

[06:02:22] lunch rate, lower achievement. But notice in 2019, that same relationship had become steeper, That there was a bigger gap between the low and higher poverty districts. And then in 2023, that gap was even larger.

[06:02:46] Okay, I showed math. Similar story, a little bit less extreme in reading. Now, why don't I just close by just opening up a discussion of just, you know, what now? So identify just four relatively short-term things that are worth considering.

[06:03:10] First, one way to think about the resumption of the accountability system is as a way to address the parent misperception issue, that it will be a surprise for many parents to find out that their school districts are struggling, but in some sense, it would be helpful to local school district leadership to potentially ask for and start to do the more controversial things that

[06:03:44] will be required in order to help students catch up. A second thing to consider is under federal law, SEA states have authority to redirect 3% of the Title I funding for direct student services like high-intensity tutoring. As far as I know, right now, only one state currently does that, state of Ohio. And that's not a huge pot of money. That's 3% of the Title I dollars.

[06:04:17] But those are dollars that the SEA could be using to direct to things like high-intensity tutoring. A third idea is just, again, statewide mobilization to get other organizations like local government, employers, community organizations to help to lower student absenteeism.

[06:04:44] It's going to be difficult or impossible for districts to catch up if absenteeism rates remain high. Can you say that one more time for me? Just say it one more time. So a statewide mobilization of local government employers and community organizations to help lower student absenteeism.

[06:05:09] I don't think there's any way students are going to catch up until we get absenteeism rates down. And think about this, like up until now, this education recovery has fallen on school superintendent leaders, school leaders, teachers, principals, and there are very few things that a mayor can do to help.

[06:05:35] Most mayors can't teach Algebra I, but a mayor can do a public service campaign around trying to lower absenteeism. Same with employers, you know, same with other community organizations. I think it's that even, you know, it wouldn't necessarily cost that much money to do, but I think could really go a long way to help resolve the achievement gaps that have widened up.

[06:06:07] And a fourth idea is targeting state incentives for academic recovery rather than across the board's salary, you know, spending targeted efforts to focus on, you know, improving academic outcomes.

[06:06:29] I know that, for instance, the state has provided some additional money on top of the federal money that expired in September. The more that's directed towards academic recovery, the better off students will be.

[06:06:46] In Texas, there's a program called the Additional Day School Year Program, where basically the state hasn't required, but basically provides an incentive for school districts to extend the school year. So

the state will chip in half of their typical state allotment for each additional day beyond the 180-day school year. And so districts don't have to extend the school

[06:07:19] year, but here's state money that is targeted at encouraging districts to provide additional learning. So, many districts in Texas have used it to expand summer learning. Here's a medium or longer-term idea is to create, and this is less about academic recovery, short-term academic recovery, and more about getting the state back on a longer-term improvement trajectory. And that

[06:07:56] is this state innovation challenge where if there were a pot of money that the state set aside for piloting and testing interventions, for instance, targeted at chronic absenteeism or targeted at middle school math or targeted at summer learning, but where the state would invest the resources in comparing what happened to the districts that got the money to what happened to the

[06:08:33] districts that didn't get the money, and then share the results around the state to help basically provide better evidence for local decision makers on how they could be or should be spending their state and local money by doing piloting and testing interventions on a regular basis. I've often said that the agencies that we entrust with managing our children's learning are actually terrible at learning themselves. And this would be a mechanism to

[06:09:09] make that possible, to continuously learn about which are the most effective ways to help students recover. So anyway, I'm sorry I've gone on so long, but I'll stop there and open up for questions.

[06:09:26] I think that we're all very attentive to every word that you're saying, and certainly I'm hanging on every word. Are there any board members that have questions? Dr. Bright? Yeah, thank you so much for this. I'm wondering if you've, and forgive me if you addressed this in here and I missed it. Have you been able to disentangle chronic absenteeism, like the effects of that from the effects of poverty? So if you were to control for chronic absenteeism, what are the effects of, you know, higher poverty rates beyond that? So that's why I soft pedaled that

[06:10:05] graph a little bit. I think we need to learn more about, because obviously there's a relationship between chronic absenteeism and poverty. So we'll be learning a lot more over the next year or two about what the separate role of chronic absenteeism is.

[06:10:26] But I think that there's, you know, prior evidence on just the importance of instructional time and of student absenteeism impacts on student achievement. You know, I think we know enough now to know that we need to be getting absenteeism rates back down.

[06:10:50] Actually, here was one interesting thing that on a research project we were doing a few years ago, where we were measuring what was the impact on learning of each day a kid missed. And it turns out students were learning more than a day's worth of learning for each day that they missed.

[06:11:16] And you might say, wait a minute, how does that make sense? Well, here's how it makes sense. Obviously, I missed the day that I was out. But the first day back, I'm not capturing 100% of what's going on because kids move past me.

[06:11:33] Maybe I get 75% of what's going on. Then the next day, I maybe get 80% of what's going on. And the next day, I get 90% of what's going on. And then if there are lots of kids missing, it's just a different group of kids missing, you know, each day.

[06:11:56] Just imagine that spills over onto all the other kids in the classroom. So I think that there's reason to believe that absenteeism had its own causal effect. I can't tell you exactly, I can't yet apportion out how much was due to absenteeism.

[06:12:18] Oh, yeah. I would not dispute that absenteeism has a huge effect in it. I'm just wondering if anybody's been able to see that. Yeah, not yet. Dr. Bryce, Dr. Myers, who is our deputy over innovation and research, is part of a group with AEI Attendance Works and Ed Trusts, and they are studying that. So we are excited to be one of a couple of states that are really looking at pulling out attendance and looking at that exponential impact of missing days. So we should have some Virginia-specific data towards spring. I also think that's another area in which parents

[06:12:53] really don't have a great grasp. I mean, I see some parents pushing back on what constitutes chronic absenteeism, and they're like, well, 18 days, that's not that much. I mean, my kid gets sick a lot, you know? Like, you know, my kid needs to be able to recover at home. It's like, well, yeah, your kid needs to be able to, yes, get sick and recover at home, but that is a lot.

[06:13:15] ATDs is a lot. Other questions, comments, Mr. Hanson? Thank you so much, Dr. Kanan. I really love slide 17, both from a national perspective, but also from a Virginia perspective.

[06:13:34] I had the opportunity back in the mid-90s to be on the Champion Schools Commission on the Future of Public Education when we put our DESOL process in place, and it just feels a little deja vu now as we're trying to put our accountability framework in place um because i didn't know then um or even could envision that it would have had that much of a delta creator of right you know an uptick for the commonwealth versus um the national and likewise with no child left behind uh you know

[06:14:10] being part of that and also just the trajectory for that next five year both nationally and before Virginia as well but those recommendations that you have at the end I think there's some are incremental some are hopefully game changers but just if we really have one or two things to focus on I would put our new accountability framework there because you really can't improve what you don't measure and I think it's just critical for both the SOLs when they're put into place in CLB

[06:14:47] and the resources as as well as the the innovation and the the system changes that were put into place but um i don't want to put you on the spot but is there one two or three top things to not just help uh change the trajectory but to also um help virginia get back um instead of uh uh on the grade four math where we're you know really greater down to the the national average but to

[06:15:20] you know help uh uh distinguish us again uh and and again this is uh you know impacting especially the lowest um uh and the most challenged students in the commonwealth so i i feel like we have we We as a field have done a terrible job telling the story of what has been happening with school reform over the last 30 or 40 years.

[06:15:50] I think if you asked most politicians, most voters, I think there would be the impression that, gosh, education's a quagmire. We've made no progress. Actually, we made remarkable progress from 1990 through 2013.

[06:16:08] So my home state, North Carolina, saw almost a whole standard deviation rise in eighth grade math scores between 1990 and 2013. So not everybody has an emotional reaction to standard deviations like me. But just to give you a much more concrete sense, that is basically the size of the black-white achievement gap. They moved the whole state by almost a whole standard deviation.

[06:16:40] Same in Virginia. I bet you Virginia is not very far behind. I bet Virginia's growth during that period was probably around 0.7 standard deviations. And because we didn't tell that story of the progress, I think that there's a sense of futility now that has infected our process.

[06:17:14] we need to go back and look at what was working during that period. I think we also learned that accountability wasn't enough and that accountability was enough to get us so far, but then we started to flatten out around 2013. And that's why I was proposing, Bill, a mixture. So returning to the accountability system, I actually, I think just because of the achievement losses during the pandemic, lowering absenteeism and providing incentive sticks, you know, provide additional

[06:17:51] days of learning, potentially through summer learning, makes sense now, maybe, you know, not forever, but certainly in the short term. But the thing that would hopefully get us back on the growth curve would be that the innovation fund, you know, idea. It wouldn't have to be a large fund. In Massachusetts, for instance, I've been arguing for, say, a $10, $15 million fund,

[06:18:20] just for each year, funding, piloting promising ideas, but just doing so with a strategy to measure whether or not that idea made a difference, and then meeting every year to discuss what we've learned. And then the SEA could potentially use its instruments to incentivize districts to, you know, adopt some of the things that were shown more effective. Although I'd be optimistic that just providing better evidence to school boards around the Commonwealth would have an impact on

[06:18:58] what people chose to do. Hopefully that wasn't too long an answer. And just, I haven't spent a good deal at the federal level, just part of your ideas, which I love them all. It even seems with, you know, just the dynamics of the election in two weeks, there could be an opportunity as well for the, some federal dollars to be, I'm just very disappointed at the, you know, spend of the dollars of the $190 billion. And obviously the impact is not what we needed. But again,

[06:19:37] sometimes people want to create a panacea, you know, from a national level, but just even the innovation ideas or some of the intervention ideas of more flexible spending. We even heard that from our teacher or the administrators this morning at four districts that we were recognizing for innovation. The one word that came out of that was flexibility. That's what they were asking for, but just, I don't know if you've looked at this federally or nationally as well, but just anything that could be done with more flexible i mean so here would be one way to do the flexibility

[06:20:13] would be in the spirit of this innovation fund idea to just say okay we're going to give additional flexibility to a group of school districts but we're going to track outcomes and if we find actually that by doing that those districts saw substantial improvements over time then maybe we'll, you know, expand the same flexibility to others. Like, I think we have to be much more humble about what is going to work to improve, you know, student outcomes. I can tell you that

[06:20:50] over the years, I've been involved in evaluations of things that I was super optimistic were going to make a big difference. I wouldn't have worked on projects that I didn't have optimism around, at least at the beginning. And so many of them turned out not to work. And this is not unique to education. Like 80% of pharmaceuticals fail during clinical trials. That it's just too hard to anticipate all the, you know, complications and unintended consequences. And so we just got

[06:21:27] to get much more in the mode of that's, you know, I got to have some reason to think it's a good idea, but before we scale it up, let's try it in a small set and measure effects, and then let everybody else try.

Now, people might say, well, isn't that just experimenting? No, it's not, actually. Districts are constantly experimenting. It's just a much more reasonable approach to experimenting. It's irresponsible to launch an initiative without any plan to know whether or

[06:22:03] not at work. So there's experimentation going on all the time, just not in any systematic way that we can learn from. Dr. King, you've talked a lot about innovation and experimentation, and I think through ESSER, some states really leaned into some innovation. I know some states had statewide summer programming. Have you studied any of the innovations that people used as a state since we're a state board and a state agency. Have you seen any statewide innovation that you're seeing

[06:22:36] faster impact? So there are some statewide, you know, tutoring programs that I've not been involved in evaluations, you know, of. But so I feel like the evidence is still accumulating on which of the state initiatives had an impact. You're right that some states like Massachusetts, I didn't talk about the Massachusetts results, but

[06:23:14] Massachusetts took a backseat and basically stood back and said, look, we have very little regulatory authority here. We're just going to watch districts spend down the federal money. And what happened was the higher poverty districts in Massachusetts did the opposite of catching up between 22 and 23.

[06:23:39] They fell further behind between 22 and 23. And so I think there was a lack of collective action around the country.

[06:23:55] Not everybody, but I do think that was part of the problem. Well, you saw major initiatives in Texas, Louisiana, Tennessee had four weeks of summer programming that was mandatory. I just didn't know if you had seen those states that did the opposite of Massachusetts see impact.

[06:24:13] So one thing that Texas did that we have done some evaluation of was they said for students that were scoring below in the bottom proficiency category on the state test, the state required districts to provide at least 30 hours of small group instruction to those students or assign the teacher of distinction. So there's a teacher incentive

[06:24:51] fund there. And we saw effects of both of those, you know, on student recovery. Dr. Northern, then Mr. Rotherham, then Ms. Hulton. I guess my question, Tom, is I feel like we're swimming in one direction and now I'm worried other states are swimming in another direction. Our direction is hold high standards. We've had an era of low standards. Now we need to

[06:25:28] hold high standards given some of these NAEP results that we're seeing. The conversation in other states, and correct me if I'm wrong, I just had a conversation with NWA the other day And they're like, okay, we've got three years of solid, you know, post-COVID trend data, and we're going to recalculate our norms, which is code word for we're going to lower the standards now.

[06:25:50] Because instead of trying to get us back to 2019, we're going to say, well, the kids have been doing really bad these last three years, so we're going to recalculate now what it means to be, you know. And I'm wondering, one, whether you are seeing that conversation play out in multiple states.

[06:26:08] I don't see it playing out at NAEP, thank goodness. And I can just trust that if we keep chugging ahead like we are in Virginia, that sooner or later, because we know that these things don't happen overnight, we know that we've got to play the long game here. And I'm trusting that if we stick to our guns

and play the long game, support districts, do the transparency we've been talking about, that we're going to see a different set of of slides here uh in several years so i guess talk to us just a little bit more generally about the climate given the the pandemic loss the learning loss and this sort of sort of throwing in the in the towel we're seeing in some cases and and what you think that's going to mean for the country

[06:26:47] so in massachusetts in two weeks there's a ballot initiative to eliminate the mcas the graduation requirement. And, you know, of course, we don't know how that ballot initiative is going to go, but just the fact that it's on the ballot in Massachusetts, I think, is telling.

[06:27:09] I think it's, again, I think it's partially our own fault for how we have told the story of what's happened over the last 30 years. I think we've allowed a narrative to develop that education is a hopeless quagmire and that accountability doesn't work. In fact, nothing systematically works in education, even though, as I said, if you had told me in 1990, the state of North Carolina

[06:27:49] is going to see almost a whole standard deviation improvement in eighth grade math between 1990 and 2013, I would have said, no way. So there was remarkable progress. And I think we're paying the price now for that. I do, I mean, that's the discouraging sign. On the hopeful sign, There are a number of states, including Virginia, that have ambitious plans around raising student literacy.

[06:28:27] And as the results emerge, I'm sure that some of those interventions are going to prove to make a difference. And hopefully that will help like rebuild people's sense that we can make progress.

[06:28:50] Hopefully that'll be the story in a couple of years here in Virginia. The, you know, the new accountability framework you guys have been working on had, you know, a positive impact on student achievement. Of course, we don't know that yet, but hopefully that'll be part of the narrative.

[06:29:07] So I think there has been a lot of retreat, retreating from accountability in recent years. And you can see it. It's not just that Virginia's down, the whole country flattened out and has seen some decline.

[06:29:26] Massachusetts has declined quite a bit from our peak in 2015. Yeah. So, it's not limited to Virginia, but I think we've got to redevelop our sense that education, like almost every area, is, you know, student achievement can be affected by policy and will be affected by policy.

[06:30:06] first of all uh dr king thank you for traveling down here i know you have a busy schedule parks i know where you're going to be next week so i know how much you're on the road uh and we're grateful and dr coons thank you for setting this up i think it's incredibly important um and so i want to thank all those unsung here okay well thank you to you and all the formerly unsung now sun apparently heroes um uh this is great uh so thank thank you and i i should just acknowledge this is not the kind of conflict of interest that's going to um make our friend love shutter but i am i am on tom's advisory board so we do have a professional relationship but as you've probably already seen from everything he said that more generally involves him advising me

[06:30:45] than the other way around um but um i should i just want to i want to acknowledge that i have a couple of questions first that's why it's because like i worry you you even in this conversation a little bit here outside like it's too late okay this happened mistakes were made like it's all just very succinctly like is it too late no okay so um so we we have evidence that high dosage tutoring it makes a difference we have evidence that summer learning makes a difference we we

[06:31:24] we um and it's just that we have not done those at the scale necessary um it's unfortunate that the federal dollars um have have expired and and you know we we don't have the 24 nape uh yet so the 24 nape comes out in in late uh january uh we'll know more then so some of my you know we'll

[06:31:55] see i i hope there's a pleasant surprise um but it's likely we won't have uh returned to 2019 levels when the 24 data come out. But because the federal money has expired, I think we have to recognize it's going to rely on state leadership at this point. So I'm not one to be pointing

[06:32:31] fingers based on decisions made around school closures. I think we all remember how much uncertainty there was about both the public health consequences and the educational consequences of school closures. It just means that based on what we know now, the states that were closed for longer just have more work to do to help students catch up. Our duly elected officials made

[06:33:02] different decisions about public health in 2020. And it's just that those same officials now have a duty to help students catch up. And if we don't, what we're doing is we're telling children, disproportionately poor children, that they have to pay the price for public health measures that were taken mostly on our behalf, you know, not necessarily on kids' behalf. Kids were less

[06:33:40] affected by the virus. It was more we were concerned about the adults or elderly parents at home or grandparents at home. And wouldn't it be ironic if we let these losses stand that kids will have paid the price for public health measures meant to benefit us?

[06:33:58] Bars and schools were open. We should, excuse me, bars and restaurants were open. Schools were closed. We should. Yeah, I'm not sure. I'm not sure on the same side as that one. But yes, I take your point. So, okay, we have a problem, and I mean, it may be in politics to say so, but we have, like, there is absolutely, I think, across the community here in Virginia, not a shared understanding about the gravity of the problem, the things, some of the things on the charts you shared.

[06:34:29] We have people come in here, and they testify to us that this whole thing is cooked up to make the schools look bad and so forth. What have you seen? What advice do you have? Because it seems to me like a predicate towards addressing it exactly what you're talking about and being able to address it in a bipartisan way is just a common back base and understanding about where we are, where we need to get to.

[06:34:52] What advice do you have for us? I know you do work with Learning Heroes and they're out there trying to do this. What have you seen that works? I know you're not an expert on Virginia, but you live in North Carolina, but to the extent you've seen, what are we not doing that we should be or are doing that we shouldn't?

[06:35:08] just help us how do we because i i don't believe it's too late either but i do worry it's getting late in the day politically on this and so yeah what what should we be doing so you know one idea that that i have to admit i have not seen tested um but uh which it would be to inform parents in

[06:35:39] the spring semester if their child is below is behind grade level um unfortunately the the scores tend to come out after parents have already made decisions about whether or not to send their child to summer learning um and uh and so um you know we're not doing parents any favors but by not telling them uh that their child is is below grade level uh so that would be one thing and i think having rather than have that information come in the form of a letter from the you know the

[06:36:16] department of education i think it would be more effective if teachers and you know and principals were informing families uh um that their child is is below grade level um and um and it's just a matter of helping parents make make the decisions that that they need to make that to help their child catch up anything else we you would recommend we do on the communication piece so making the success i mean you you yeah line about standard deviations was was funny but yeah yeah

[06:36:52] yeah so how do we put this in terms so here so here would be you know uh one um piece of information is so we looked back at at states that had big increases in the nape versus versus states that had smaller increases and we said well what happened to the people born in those states in terms of their in those years in terms of their income educational attainment teen motherhood

[06:37:25] rates arrest rates and all of those improved more in in the in the the places that had bigger increases in the name which implies it's not just test scores like the that that and even calculate What the payoff to Virginia residents was of the increase in the NAEP scores during the 90s and 2000s, and then what the cost to the future economy would be if there is no recovery, might be a way to just try to get the word across.

[06:38:01] because a lot of parents have an ambivalent relationship to test scores, you know, so connecting it more to longer-term outcomes, I think, you know, might help. Thank you. Okay, Ms. Holden and then Ms. McPherson. Again, thank you, Dr. Cain with no eye for joining us.

[06:38:26] He reminded me, his cane has no eye, gave me that joke. And we met many years ago and reminded me again today. Seriously, it's been really valuable. I love your seed money center idea.

[06:38:42] We in Virginia actually do seed money for innovative programs, like extended school year. We've got grants for them. We just don't ever study them or scale them. We teach the scientific method. We just don't use it. Right, right. And, you know, I'm making a blanket statement, but extended school year is a perfect example where our General Assembly has been funding seed money for extended school year for a long time.

[06:39:08] But studying and then scaling, that piece just hasn't happened. I appreciate your comment about how we've moved the needle on averages over a matter of decades in Virginia, as well as North Carolina, elsewhere.

[06:39:25] My one piece on your optimism is we haven't moved the achievement gaps meaningfully for the most part. I mean, there's pieces, but over the decades of effort, we would have all hoped we could close those achievement gaps or come close to closing them, and we haven't.

[06:39:48] And so that comment leads me to first my two questions, and I'll do them both and let you address them. But going back to your slide, the barrier number four, lack of understanding what recovery, I love that slide, the tutors, double math, summer school, extended school year, all of those are proven methods, not just you're using pre-pandemic research, but those would not just help us address learning loss from the pandemic, but would help us close achievement gaps, those longstanding achievement gaps, if we funded them at scale.

[06:40:21] Am I right about that? So if implemented well, yes. And I think even though there is pre-pandemic research, I think it's worthwhile continuing to track which kids are getting tutors and which kids aren't, if only just to be able to see if we're getting the gains that were hoped that the pre-pandemic research suggested we ought to see.

[06:40:50] and will help identify implementation, you know, issues and challenges. For communication purposes and for implementation monitoring, absolutely, we need to be studying and evaluating, even when we take those solutions to scale.

[06:41:07] Yes. But so my question to you is, I mean, there are some things that don't necessarily cost money, as you were saying, the ad campaign about absenteeism. I mean, Virginia's absenteeism was one of the lowest in the nation pre-pandemic, doubled during the pandemic has come back down considerably, but it's still way worse than pre-pandemic. So I'm all in on, excuse the pun, but that's one of our themes in Virginia. I'm all in on messaging campaigns that don't cost very much on absenteeism. These solutions in barrier, in your slide titled barrier four, all cost money. The tutors, double math, summer school,

[06:41:45] extended school year. And my question is, they cost not a little, but a lot of money. Do you have any advice for us about how to make the case to scale up the kind of resources that's necessary to implement those solutions at scale in our high poverty schools? And I will tell you that, I don't know how much you've looked at the Virginia finance system, but

[06:42:10] Our high poverty schools, on average, get about, if they get as much as the high wealthier schools get per capita, then it's barely, if you add up all their different funding sources.

[06:42:26] And our state in particular has been underfunding its share of public education widely. So we're one of those states where local property taxes make a big impact and wealthier divisions chip in more and get better outcomes and hire all the good teachers, et cetera, et cetera.

[06:42:45] I'm sorry, getting to the question, I have seen research saying that the high poverty divisions to fund programs like that and get results need 30 to 50 percent more per student on average to get to close achievement gaps.

[06:43:03] What's your sense of is that in the right ballpark and do you have any advice for us how to get there? So I don't have, you know, here's how much more money would be necessary to close the gaps.

[06:43:17] But I do think that there is a connection between the Innovation Fund and this funding point is if we could be providing evidence along the way that, you know, not just that, oh, there was pre-pandemic research that suggested high dosage tutoring made a difference.

[06:43:45] But as implemented here in Virginia, here was the growth in student achievement that was resulted from high dosage, high intensity tutoring. Or, you know, we funded these summer learning programs.

[06:44:03] We had this pilot program. Here was the effect of, you know, providing additional summer learning to students. I think that would help build the political case for expanding these programs.

[06:44:21] And even if there's an evaluation that is part of, it's not just that trust us, we know that this is going to work. We've planned this so that we'll be able to tell you whether or not it's working as it's being scaled up.

[06:44:40] You know, the, you know, the department has, you know, longitudinal, you know, data system that could be used for this, you know, purpose to be tracking the efficacy of a wide range of things. It's just, it's a matter of just tracking which kids are getting what and measuring achievement gains.

[06:44:59] And we could do some of that even retroactively, so to speak. So, for instance, you pointed, well, but you pointed to the example, for instance, of the Richmond City Schools extended school year. You know, we can't go back and do randomized controlled trials, but we can look at school to schools, high poverty that have not succeeded and then implemented extended school year.

[06:45:20] And then they're succeeding, you know, making rapid gains, but we still don't scale it up. And I just hate the notion. I mean, I like the notion of the center, but we can't wait till we've got a center up and running and getting results.

[06:45:36] We've got to figure out how to fund these kind of interventions for kids now. And so I come back to, I mean, I know you're in my colleague, Matt Steinberg did this calculation of what it would take dollar wise nationwide, you know, that ESSER was only a quarter of what it needed to be, you know, to recover nationwide.

[06:45:57] I don't know whether that number has any relevance to our discussion here in Virginia, but I'd be interested in what's your estimate of how much more do we need to be funding our high poverty schools to close gaps? So I think if things were targeted, so I won't come up with a specific dollar amount, but I think if dollars were targeted at increasing summer learning,

[06:46:27] So as I mentioned, in Texas, with the additional day school year program, said we're not going to require school districts to extend the year, but for districts that want to add days beyond 180 days.

[06:46:47] And by the way, that wasn't contingent on every kid having to get it. So they would pay half the cost for each individual child that is spending more than 180 days. So that's, you know, targeted money, targeted exactly at, you know, trying to help students recover from learning loss.

[06:47:12] But you have nothing to offer us on what kind of money that costs, what kind of percentage increase that would take. Well, so it would take whatever the state, you know, so I can't do it off the top of my head, but it's not rocket science. Like, you know, take like what the state's allocation is, divide it by 180 days.

[06:47:34] 20 extra days is over 180. It's a 10% increase. Yeah. Ms. McPherson and then Mr. Rotherham. And then Dr. Rotherham. Dr. Zane, certainly we do appreciate you being here today and information is invaluable.

[06:47:51] I just want to make sure that I'm clear about a couple of things. I heard you say when interpreted that marginalized communities, low-income communities, poverty schools that have a high population of poverty students does not necessarily mean that those students are not achieving at a level that other students are achieving.

[06:48:15] And in fact, they have shown some significant improvement post-pandemic as it relates to their ability to catch up. so it appears to me that what you said is we need to go back and tell the story about there was past success there's been a period where there has not been success and the story needs to be told accurately so that parents community individuals and industries get a full

[06:48:49] picture of where we are I think we all understand where Virginia is performing at this point and And as Ms. Houghton has said, we really don't have a whole lot of time as it relates to studies that are going to impact what we're going to do next.

[06:49:06] So I think Virginia is taking a position that the first thing we need to do is tell the story, tell the story accurately, and then move directly into accountability. And as a part of that accountability, it appears, I'm hearing you say, we need to drill down on the numbers, do more reporting of the numbers, making sure the teachers and the parents both understand where we are and that we move forward and implement in conjunction with this storytelling

[06:49:38] these innovative projects? So, yes. I mean, one clarification I would want to make is, like, there are some school districts that have made remarkable progress in recovery. So Birmingham, Alabama, the superintendent there, Mark Sullivan, like many high poverty districts around the country, they lost a lot of ground between 19 and 22. But they actually improved by about a half a

[06:50:17] grade level in math in that 22 to 23 school year. And he did it with like a range of different kind of interventions, but we need to be lifting up those. So there certainly are communities that have, that had big losses and that have managed substantial recoveries. And we need to be celebrating, you know, those successes. And it's, you know, unfortunately, in Massachusetts is the

[06:50:48] it's the wealthier districts that are the ones that have been recovering. So we I wish I had more examples of districts in Massachusetts that have made the recovery. But in most other states, there are at least a few districts that have have higher poverty districts that have seen big improvements. And the story doesn't necessarily just include where the students are not performing.

[06:51:18] Part of this story is talking about where the schools are not performing. Yeah. Just want us to be clear about that as we move forward. Yeah. You know, when you tell a parent, well, I'm sorry, your child's not doing well, that story probably should include where the performance level is of the school in which the student is attending so that the whole story is being told. And here's what we're going to do to help catch up. So as I was describing before, I do think it would be

[06:51:50] important for schools, school personnel to let parents know where their child sits, but tie it with a plan for helping students catch up. So letting parents know in spring and say, the good news is, if you agree, we'll sign your child up right now for summer learning.

[06:52:17] this summer and for a high-dosage tutor or, you know, and so forth. So I totally agree. It's got to be combined with individual student-level plans, and it can't just be, you know, just, you know, bad news that implies that there's something that the child has done wrong as opposed to what, you know, what they've been exposed to.

[06:52:49] Rotherham. Thank you, Matt. Yeah, I want to pick up on exactly the point that Ms. McPherson put down, and I feel like, and I know this is certainly not Ms. Holton's intent, but I feel like it can be some confusion. We have struggled to narrow the achievement gap, absolutely, and that's, I mean, that's not a Virginia thing, that's a national thing, that's a front and center problem in education, but when we talk about how we've shifted the curve or overall improvement, like for all students, and that includes students who are on the wrong end of the achievement gap right now, they have also seen improvements.

[06:53:23] I worry that can sometimes get heard as it's sort of hopeless. And we should there's not a lot we should do. And as you and I have discussed, that can lead to this sort of like almost like palliative approach to education rather than approach that says we should have high standards, support people, have accountability and so forth, that there's efficacy here.

[06:53:43] And so I just want to I get it. I know that was not certainly not Miss Holden's intent to reply that, but it can sometimes be heard that way. I just want to be absolutely clear. We've seen progress for those kids. We saw that progress eroded because of the pandemic, and now we need to, but the efficacy is a real thing here.

[06:54:01] So, Andy, there's even, just a, I realize you didn't get a chance to, the question, but just on that, I realize I didn't speak about this, but we actually, between 1990 and 2013, We made substantive progress in narrowing the black-white achievement gap and the white-Hispanic achievement gap. We closed the gap by, I think, about a fifth of the gap in 1990, you know,

[06:54:36] had shrunk by 2013. The important thing to remember is we were swimming upstream during that period, income inequality was rising. Wealth inequality was rising. Income-based, you know, residential segregation was increasing. And, you know, we all know schools are heavily influenced by the degree of income-based income segregation. So despite that, we had been

[06:55:07] making progress in narrowing the black-white achievement gap. And actually, although this is, I have to say, this is something on which there is conflicting research, but, and you might say, gosh, like how could there possibly still be a disagreement on whether or not income-based achievement gaps were narrowing over time? It's a long story. It has to do with, in the National

[06:55:38] assessment of educational progress, we don't ask about parents' income. But when my team merged the schools surveyed in the NAEP to the neighborhood income surrounding those schools in the census, and just to ask what happened to income-based achievement gaps over time,

[06:56:05] There was a substantial narrowing starting around 2003. And again, despite the fact that wealth inequality was rising and income-based achievement gaps were narrowing, I believe we were making progress in the narrowing income-based achievement gaps, although I'm quick to stipulate that that is a disputed finding.

[06:56:34] I'm arguing with, our team is arguing with another team on this, but it is indisputable that the black-white achievement gap was narrowing some through that. Right. I don't think any of us are happy with it or would declare mission accomplished.

[06:56:52] But just the overall, when you have overall improvement, it means everybody's doing better, even if we're not getting to where we want to be yet on those gaps. I disagree on why they exist. I think we can get there, and I certainly don't think it's the kids. and it's not something in the water. It's decisions that we choose to make or not make, which brings me to my second point. I hear your analysis, and I'm always very leery to disagree with you, but I will disagree with you a little bit here, that, okay, you take 180 days, break it up into its component parts, and then add, you know, plus X for how many days you want. I think that's incorrect, because, and there's a word I'm going to use, we don't like to use around here,

[06:57:29] the P word, productivity. And you have plenty of examples, like in the city where you live in Boston, the charter schools there, the last time they were seriously evaluated by Credo, 180 extra days of learning. That's like an extra school year, right? Like going on in the same, that wasn't because I'm all for spending more. I'm on record. I think we need to spend more on schools in Virginia. We need to spend it in smarter ways than we do now, but they did. That's not what drove that in Boston. It was things that these schools did. We've seen that elsewhere. And I think we have to also think about, okay, we need extended

learning time. There are certainly cost and i'm not wishing that away but there are also things we can do to generate greater

[06:58:09] productivity and we sort of take that off the table and there are not other industries that sort of would approach a problem in that sort of linear of a way they would there's other things and and so i just want to push on that i just want to push on that a little bit because i think yeah so so when i'm in answering um uh and sorry and questions i wasn't sure whether whether dr Holton or Mrs. Holton or when I tied up in my head. So, but when I was answering Anne's question,

[06:58:46] I was trying to put together an estimate of what it would cost. I wasn't saying literally for every additional day you'd get. I do believe the evidence is pretty strong that you'd get an achievement gain for additional days, but whether or not it's equivalent to the prior 180 days, I'm enough of an economist to understand declining marginal productivity. But I do think, though, that's why this innovation fund is critical. It is a mechanism for identifying

[06:59:26] productivity increases. It is a mechanism for identifying how we could be getting bigger gains per dollar spent. Yeah, I agree completely. And I think we learned this lesson, obviously, with extended learning time. So during the Clinton administration, we expanded it. Schools did academic stuff. They got academic benefits. They did other stuff. You didn't see that. Or if the academic program was strong, doing 30% more of it didn't get you. So I think I worry we always get these conversations. It's not an or, it's an and. We need to spend more time. Again, as you said, this isn't rocket science. Get the kids in school, get them in front of high quality teachers

[07:00:03] and good curriculum. And lo and behold, you get better results. And we need to be thinking about some of these other pieces and so forth. And I just want to make sure, because I worry we can quickly get to where people come out with these estimates and then say, oh my gosh, that's so expensive. We can never do that. And then everybody throws up their hands rather than then there are things we can do that will put a dent in this. I agree. Dr. Lorna. So just a couple of quick points. A few months ago, we at Fordham started doing a series of briefs called Think Again,

[07:00:41] where we took on some common myths that we see in the education community. And so we wrote one a few months back. It's actually one of our most downloaded reports ever. And it's called, Is Education Funding in America Still Unequal? And we tried to bring together all the research.

[07:00:57] And what we found is in the 90s, in the era of Jonathan Kozol and Savage Inequalities, that absolutely there was less money going to poor schools and poor kids. But since that time, the investment across the country has just, you know, skyrocketed.

[07:01:13] And actually, in I think all but three states, funding systems are now progressive, meaning that the students from the poor families are generally attending better funded schools than kids from more wealthy families. That's also the case in Virginia.

[07:01:29] Regardless of what J. Lark may or may not say, what happens sometimes is that a report will only take into consideration one source of funding. So they'll only look at local, or they'll only look at state, or they'll only look at state and local, but not federal. And the federal dollars have become increasingly more, increasingly more part of the proportion of student funding. So a report came out a few years ago by Urban Institute, Matt Chingos, happy to share this with the board if they're interested.

[07:01:56] And there's state by state, there's this lovely little graph state by state of each state. And And when you click on Virginia, you see that if you just look at local funding, we're regressive, meaning that we're giving more money to the wealthier schools. But if you look at local, federal, state, local, state and federal altogether, we become progressive again where we're targeting more money to to the poor kids.

[07:02:21] And so I feel like, and it's not just in Virginia, I feel like nationally, we've had this conversation for so long that we're unequally funding. I mean, you know, there's a gap. And if you care to look at a research brief about this, I mean, study after study after study by think tanks on the right, by think tanks on the left, by think tanks in the middle.

[07:02:42] And they're all coming down on this used to be a huge problem, and now it's not. And in Virginia, if you only look at one source of funding, you will see that it's aggressive. But if you look at all channels of funding, you'll see that, I mean, if you look at all channels, you'll see that we're progressive. So I just want us to make sure that we're all up to date with the latest research, not only nationally, but also in our commonwealth.

[07:03:08] Okay. We thank you so much, Dr. Cain. Well, thanks for having me. For coming today, for providing us all of your expertise and knowledge. And certainly, I wouldn't be surprised if we continue to reach out to you for more of your knowledge and expertise as we continue to progress through these conversations.

[07:03:32] And so, we wish you safe travels home. And I think that that ends our day today. Do you have anything that you want to say? Okay. So, that ends our work session for the day.

[07:03:48] And I will see you all back here at 9 a.m. tomorrow. Thank you.